

The FAFSA, Step by Step

*A Parent's Plain-English Guide to the 2027-28 Form:
Accounts, Assets, Awards and Appeals*

Priya Raman

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The Laptop Closed Itself

Rohan had the FAFSA open for four minutes. Then he hit a screen that said the form needed a “contributor,” closed the laptop, and went to go mow the Pattersons’ lawn instead.

I didn’t chase him. I’ve watched that exact moment happen at my counter. For sixteen years I ran the front office at a high school north of Austin, and every January brought a line of parents holding a form they’d half-filled and half-understood. The word that stops people cold isn’t usually a hard one. It’s an unfamiliar one. “Contributor” sounds like a summons. It isn’t.

Rohan needed to know who would have to answer with him. For our form, that included me. A contributor supplies their part of the form and, when required, gives consent and approval to use tax information and signs; Chapter 2 explains what that means. Nobody is being deposed.

What this form actually is

The FAFSA is long. It saves your progress. You do not have to finish in one sitting. When I helped families at school, some needed a break to check a number. Save a draft when you need to check a number. Before submitting, return to every required question, complete every contributor section and signature, and confirm the form was received. That’s normal. If a question makes you stop and stare at the screen, that’s not a sign you’re doing it wrong. It’s a sign the form is doing its job, which is asking for specific numbers instead of guesses.

The 2027-28 FAFSA form is live. StudentAid.gov says it uses 2025 tax information for attendance from July 1, 2027 through June 30, 2028. The 2027-28 handbook guidance is not yet published, so this book labels handbook rules 2026-27 and sends you to StudentAid.gov for current instructions.

The book follows the questions a family hits sitting at the table together. First, the accounts and the consent that let the form run at all. Then the questions that trip people up hardest: who counts as a parent when a marriage has ended, what a small business or a farm has to report, what counts as an asset and what doesn't. Then what the form does with everything you've told it: the number it produces at the end, and what that number does and doesn't mean. Only after that number exists do we get to the part nobody warns you about. That's reading the award letter a school sends back, so a loan doesn't get mistaken for a gift, and knowing when and how to ask a school to look again if your family's situation has changed.

I'm not going to hand you a 2027-28 Pell Grant dollar figure, because the Department of Education hadn't published one at the time I wrote this, and a guess printed in a book outlives the year it was wrong about. Where a number changes every year, or by state, or by school, I'll tell you exactly where to go look it up yourself — StudentAid.gov, mostly, plus the agencies and offices named along the way. The form's layout and rules can change. Check the current award-year form and instructions at StudentAid.gov before following any step-by-step guide.

The three things families get wrong most

After watching this process from the front office, and then again as a parent myself, I've come to believe almost every FAFSA headache traces back to one of three habits.

Waiting to make the accounts. Families treat the StudentAid.gov account as step three or four, something to get to after they've found the tax return and had the big conversation about who's paying for what. Tonight is for starting, not solving every account problem. Chapter 1 owns the setup and repairs.

Treating consent as optional, or as a formality to click past. Somewhere in the form, every contributor has to consent to the IRS sending over tax information. It feels like paperwork. It is the single gate the entire application sits behind — skip it, and the form will not produce an aid number for your student, full stop, no matter how carefully everything else was filled in. I'll explain exactly what you're consenting to and why it matters this much in Chapter 2.

Reading “aid” on the award letter as if every line on it were a gift. A letter arrives from a school with a dollar figure at the top, and it's easy to read the whole thing as money that's simply yours. Some of it is. Some of it is a loan with your student's name on it, or your name on it, that gets paid back with interest. Those are very different kinds of help, and the letters don't always make the difference obvious. We'll get to reading one line by line later in this book.

What this book doesn't cover

I want to say this once, plainly, so you're not waiting for it later: this book does not teach you how to save for college, or how to think about a 529 plan as an investment strategy. Chapter 5 explains when an education savings account is reported as an asset, including cases where the form does not ask for assets; this book does not teach investment strategy. If you're looking for help building a college-savings strategy from scratch, that's a different book than this one. What you're holding is for the form that's open on your screen right now, this year, with a deadline somewhere ahead of you.

When to call someone who isn't me

I was the person at the front desk who could translate a form into plain English. I was never the person who could tell a family what to do with their tax return, their divorce decree, or their small business's books, and I'm still not. I'll tell you, plainly and by name, exactly when a chapter's topic has crossed into territory that needs a professional. A CPA or tax preparer, when a business or a rental makes the numbers genuinely unclear. The school's own financial aid office, for anything involving that school's own money. A family law attorney, when a custody order and the form's rules don't seem to agree. The Federal Student Aid Information Center, when an account or an identity check gets stuck. The school's financial aid office and federal aid help line are free; ask a CPA or attorney about fees before booking. They exist because this process has edge cases no single book can fully anticipate.

Tonight's task

Make the StudentAid.gov accounts. Record account created, email confirmed, and any status the site shows. Stop there tonight.

Rohan came back from the Pattersons' with grass clippings on his shoes and found me making my own StudentAid.gov login at the kitchen table, the one I'd need later as a contributor on his form. He watched for a second, then said, "that's it?" That's it. The rest of this book is just what comes after.

Chapter 1: Who Has to Answer, and How to Log In

Vikram made his account on a Tuesday night, typing fast because the baseball game was on in the other room. Where the form asked for his name, he typed “Vik.” Three days later his account sat at “needs action,” and neither of us could tell why until I made him read the error screen out loud.

That one word cost him a week. Let’s start before that mistake, not after it, so you don’t have to make it too.

What a contributor actually is

Under the 2026-27 Federal Student Aid Handbook’s Application and Verification Guide, a contributor is anyone required to provide information, consent and approval, and a signature on the FAFSA form. That includes the student. It includes at least one parent, if the student is a dependent. Sometimes it includes a parent’s spouse. The form is organized around this word — each contributor gets their own section, their own login, their own set of questions about their own finances. Nobody answers for anybody else.

I want to be honest about why that word lands so badly on first contact. “Contributor” sounds like something from a deposition, or a tax form you’d need a lawyer to read. It’s doing a narrower job than that. It’s naming, plainly, who has to show up and answer, as opposed to who simply cares about the outcome. A grandparent who’s helping pay tuition isn’t a contributor unless the form specifically requires it of them. A sibling isn’t one. The question the

form is actually asking, under all that formality, is “whose numbers do we need.”

That distinction matters because of what each contributor’s section asks for. It isn’t a general background check. It’s a request for that one person’s specific financial facts — income, tax filing status, certain assets — the same facts you’d expect a tax preparer to ask for, not a character reference. Knowing that in advance takes some of the sting out of the word the first time it shows up on a screen.

The reason the Department moved away from just saying “parent” is that FAFSA households don’t sort into that one word anymore. A stepparent who didn’t adopt the student might still have to answer. An ex-spouse who hasn’t lived in the house for six years might not. “Contributor” is a wider net that catches the right people regardless of what the household looks like, and Chapter 3 walks through exactly how the form decides which parent that is when parents are divorced or never married. For now, hold onto the simple version: a contributor is anyone the form requires an answer from, and each one answers for themselves.

Making the accounts

Before anyone can contribute anything, they need a StudentAid.gov account. This is the part people put off, because it feels like paperwork before the paperwork, and it’s also the part that causes the most avoidable delay if you wait.

Each contributor needs their own account: their own email address, their own username and password, never shared with anyone else in the household. Use your own StudentAid.gov account to open your section. After answering, follow the form’s separate instructions to acknowledge its terms, electronically sign your section and submit it. Chapter 2 distinguishes that signature from tax-information consent.

That order is set out on the Department’s current “Filling Out the FAFSA Form” page, and it repays a second reading, because the word “submit” does two different jobs there. You submit your own section. The form itself isn’t finished until every required contributor has completed theirs, given the tax-information permission and signed. One person racing ahead doesn’t move the application along by itself. It just means the waiting starts somewhere else.

This is also why one shared family email address causes so much trouble. If Rohan and I had both tried to use the same inbox, StudentAid.gov would have no way to tell our two accounts apart, and neither of us would be able to prove, later, that the answers under our section were ours. If you need a separate email address, create a free one that only that contributor controls. Fifteen minutes, one contributor, done — except it often isn’t done in fifteen minutes, because of what happened to Vikram.

The name-match trap

The student’s name, date of birth and Social Security number get checked against Social Security Administration records as part of making the account and filing the form. That check is strict, and it is not looking for the name people actually go by. It’s looking for the name on the card.

One qualification before the story, because it decides whether this section applies to a given person at all. If the contributor has an SSN, enter the name matching SSA’s record. If not, follow StudentAid.gov’s account and identity-verification instructions for contributors without an SSN. The account page itself hedges the same way — it asks for your name as it appears on your Social Security card *if you have one*, and for an SSN *if you have one*. Parents and spouses without Social Security numbers are expected to

show up on this form, and the identity route for them is spelled out on the site rather than in this book.

Vikram goes by Vik everywhere except his passport and his Social Security card, where he's Vikram. He typed "Vik" into the account, because that's who he is to every person who knows him. The system flagged it, because Social Security has never heard of a Vik.

Here's the part worth knowing before it happens to you: there are two different reasons this match can fail, and they need two different fixes. Ask yourself which one you're looking at before you touch anything.

Branch A: Social Security's own record is wrong. Maybe there was a legal name change after a marriage or a court order. The update never made it into SSA's system, even though everything the family typed into the FAFSA is correct and current. In that case, the fix starts with SSA, not with StudentAid.gov. Correct the record directly with the Social Security Administration, and wait for their confirmation that it's updated. From there you have two paths: ask the Federal Student Aid Information Center to manually resync the data with SSA, or ask the school to help. A school can set the record to resend for matching through its own systems and submit the fix as a correction.

Branch B: what got typed into the FAFSA was wrong. This was Vikram's branch. The name on his Social Security card was never the problem; "Vik" was a shortcut he typed without thinking about what the form would do with it. For this branch, the fix lives entirely on StudentAid.gov: log in, go to Account Settings, correct the name so it matches the Social Security card exactly, and that correction gets automatically resent to SSA for a fresh match. Once SSA verifies it, submit a FAFSA correction so the application reflects the fixed account.

Ask the one-sentence question before you do anything else: is SSA's record wrong, or is what we typed wrong? Branch A starts with

a phone call to Social Security. Branch B starts with Account Settings on StudentAid.gov. Guess wrong, and you'll spend a week waiting on the wrong fix. That's roughly what happened to us before I made Vikram read the actual error text instead of assuming.

Vikram's fix took four days once he knew which branch he was on: Account Settings, the full legal name, a resubmitted match, a FAFSA correction. If your family hits this and you're not sure which branch applies, or the status doesn't clear the way you'd expect, that uncertainty is worth a direct question to the people who run the system, not another guess.

The one case with no fix on this side of the form

There's a narrower problem worth knowing about even if it doesn't apply to your family. For 2026-27, most students applying for Title IV aid needed an SSN, but citizens of a Freely Associated State had a special no-SSN route, including online account verification. A paper application without a student SSN was returned unprocessed outside that exception. Check StudentAid.gov or the Federal Student Aid Information Center for your 2027-28 filing route before assuming you cannot file online.

I'm being this careful because the stakes of getting it wrong run in one direction. A family that wrongly believes the door is shut doesn't file at all, and nobody follows up with them. Ask first.

What the live 2027-28 form actually shows

Here's what I can tell you for certain, checked directly against StudentAid.gov: the 2027-28 FAFSA form is live. It asks for 2025 tax information. Its attendance period begins July 1, 2027 and ends June 30, 2028. That much I verified on the site itself, not in a

handbook, because the handbook for 2027-28 hadn't published a single guide page as of this writing.

So here's the honest line between the two. These account and correction mechanics come from the 2026-27 handbook. Before using them for the live 2027-28 application, follow its current StudentAid.gov instructions or ask the Federal Student Aid Information Center.

I'd rather say that twelve times in this book than let you read a handbook sentence as settled law for a cycle it was never written for.

Doing this together, at one table

The best version of this step that I've seen — in my own kitchen and at the front counter for sixteen years — involves one table and one laptop passed between people. Keep the 2025 tax return available if the live 2027-28 form asks for figures you cannot confirm without it; StudentAid.gov says most families can start without gathering documents. The form saves as you go. That's not a consolation prize; it's the actual design. You are not expected to finish the account step and the whole application in one sitting, and trying to force that usually produces the kind of rushed typing that got Vikram's name wrong in the first place.

Turn the introduction's brief account notes into a card for each required contributor. Record the person's name, their own email, whether the account was created and email confirmed, and the identity status shown by StudentAid.gov. Leave passwords and Social Security numbers off the card. Add one question if a match fails: "Is SSA's record wrong, or did we enter the wrong information?" Record which branch applies, the contact or correction made, and when you'll recheck identity status.

The repair entries build on the brief notes you started tonight. The point isn't more paperwork. It's that a week from now, when

somebody asks what you already tried, you can answer from the card instead of from memory. Memory is where these repairs go to die — one person thinks the call was made, another thinks the correction was submitted, and nobody rechecks.

When to call someone

If Account Settings won't accept a correction, call the Federal Student Aid Information Center. If SSA has confirmed a change but it has not reached your application, ask the Center or your school about a new match. Don't invent a third repair path.

The Center can see your account from the inside in a way no checklist can replace. A school is different: it can help with the resend step in Branch A, but it has no window into your personal account settings. Knowing which of the two to call saves a day on its own.

What to expect once the accounts are made

Once every contributor's account shows a verified identity status, nothing dramatic happens next. Nobody gets an email congratulating them. The account simply sits there, ready, until the next contributor logs in to start their section of the form. That quiet is part of why families underestimate this step: it doesn't feel like progress, because there's nothing to point at yet.

Which is exactly why you check instead of assume. Check each required contributor's account and identity status in StudentAid.gov. Record any outstanding action; don't assume a successful login means the account is verified.

Resist the urge to treat a verified account as license to rush through everything else at the same pace. The account step rewards care precisely because it's slow and checkable. Every later step — the

tax-information consent in Chapter 2, the parent and dependency questions in later chapters — builds on these accounts being correct. A name typed wrong here doesn't just cost a week fixing the account; it can delay every contributor's section behind it, because the form won't finish processing a signature tied to an unverified identity.

Treat the account step the way you'd treat laying a foundation: unglamorous, invisible once the rest of the house goes up, and the one place where a mistake is hardest to see until much later.

Make the accounts tonight if you haven't already, each one under the name SSA has on file for that person — or, where there's no SSN, under whatever the site's own identity route tells you to enter. Everything after this chapter — the consent screen, the parent question, the assets — assumes those accounts already exist and already match.

Chapter 2: The Consent Screen, and What the SAI Actually Is

Vikram had pushed his chair back from the kitchen table. Rohan was still leaning toward the laptop, waiting for a number that wasn't coming.

"I did my part," Vikram said.

He'd answered the questions he understood. He'd left the tax-information permission alone because he wanted to read it properly, then forgot to return. On that application he was a required contributor. His unfinished permission mattered just as much as the answers he'd carefully entered.

Rohan thought he'd broken something. Vikram thought the website was slow. I reached for the yellow pad beside the fruit bowl and wrote their names on separate lines. Beside each name: permission, signature, section complete. We needed to find the missing action, not keep refreshing.

This was our consent stumble, not a claim about a particular button or error message on your form. Public FAFSA guidance for the live form confirms that all required contributors must complete their sections, give consent and approval, and sign. Its consent instructions are usable now. I haven't verified the wording or position of buttons inside your signed-in application, so I won't invent a click sequence.

The administrative source below is the Application and Verification Guide, **2026-27** edition, within the Federal Student Aid Handbook. Check [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov) for your current cycle's instructions; an older handbook is not proof of next year's rule.

The pipe between the IRS and the form

FA-DDX. FUTURE Act Direct Data Exchange. An awkward name for a connection between the Internal Revenue Service and Federal Student Aid, part of the Department of Education.

The IRS holds federal tax information. The exchange lets the Department request specified information and use it in the aid application. You aren't uploading your whole tax folder to a stranger who offered to help.

FTI means federal tax information. I'll use "tax information" where that will do.

According to the 2026-27 guide's chapter "Filling Out the FAFSA Form," this exchange can supply income and tax information directly from the IRS. Tax information successfully transferred through it is considered verified for federal student aid purposes. It doesn't mean every answer elsewhere on the application has been checked.

The Department's live filing guidance also explains an initially unsettling feature: the transferred federal tax information won't display on the FAFSA site or the FAFSA Submission Summary. You may not get a familiar screen full of tax-return amounts to inspect.

That absence isn't, by itself, evidence of a failed transfer.

Under the 2026-27 handbook, students and contributors cannot view or edit the imported information; the school's financial aid administrator can see it on the school's application record. If you believe something is wrong, identify the concern and ask the aid office how to resolve it. Don't invent replacement amounts because you can't see the imported ones.

I like automatic entry when it saves someone from copying the wrong line. I don't like "automatic" being used to mean "nothing else to do." Follow the questions and help instructions the current form actually gives you. A tax transfer isn't the whole application.

What the permission actually permits

The permission has two directions. Your identifying information goes to the IRS so it can find the relevant record. Tax information comes back to the Department so it can evaluate student aid eligibility.

The 2026-27 guide distinguishes **consent** from **approval**. Consent permits the use and disclosure of identifying information for the IRS match. Approval permits the Department to receive, use and redisclose federal tax information for the authorized aid purposes.

Redisclose means share onward under those rules.

The same 2026-27 source names eligible institutions, state higher education agencies and designated scholarship organizations as authorized recipients for aid administration. This isn't permission for unrestricted public sharing.

For the available 2027-28 application, StudentAid.gov's current filling-out guidance describes the permission in plain terms. It includes matching identifying information with IRS records, receiving tax information, using it to determine aid eligibility and sharing it with schools and state higher education agencies. It also describes reuse on another student's FAFSA, such as when a parent contributes for another child.

Read the actual statement in your application. The explanation here helps you understand it; it doesn't replace it.

Here's the sentence I most want you to carry away: **Under the 2026-27 handbook, a student is ineligible for Title IV aid while any required contributor's tax-information approval is missing.**

Title IV is the federal student aid covered by that law, not a promise about every private scholarship. This missing permission isn't merely a preference about convenient data entry.

The current StudentAid.gov instructions likewise say that a required spouse or parent who declines the transfer permission prevents federal student aid eligibility. Typing tax information field by field does not get around that requirement.

You can pause to understand a permission. You cannot treat the pause as completion.

No tax return doesn't mean no consent

The live Department guidance explicitly addresses contributors who didn't file taxes, filed outside the United States or don't have a Social Security number. They still need to provide consent and approval.

It can feel illogical to authorize a search when you expect the search to find no return. But “there is no return to retrieve” and “I haven't authorized retrieval” are different facts. Don't substitute one for the other.

The 2026-27 handbook requires the applicant and every applicable contributor to give the permission regardless of filing method. Paper is not a consent-free alternative. Nor does the student's approval cover a parent's missing approval.

Use the contributor list from Chapter 1 rather than adding everyone in the household. The question here is whether each person who is actually required has completed this action. Choosing the correct parent in a separated family belongs to Chapter 3.

At our table, the yellow pad exposed what the phrase “I did my part” concealed. Rohan's action couldn't finish Vikram's. My knowing the household's tax information couldn't finish it either. Vikram had to return to the Department's process himself, read the permission and supply his own response.

A cycle is not a calendar year

According to the 2026-27 application guide, consent and approval are given once for that FAFSA cycle and cannot be revoked for that cycle. A new cycle requires its own permission.

Read that before agreeing. I won't describe an irreversible permission as a harmless box to click past.

The cycle is the application period associated with a particular FAFSA award year. It isn't simply January through December, and it isn't the tax year printed on a return.

The handbook illustrates this with the **2026-27** FAFSA cycle, which it describes as running from **August 2025 to September 2027**. Those dates are its example of a cycle's length. They are not the 2027-28 cycle dates, not your school's priority deadline and not advice to wait until September.

For the current window, check StudentAid.gov. Don't move the example dates forward a year and call that research.

Keep the cycle label beside your consent record. A note saying "approved last fall" becomes ambiguous when another application opens. A note naming the FAFSA year tells you which application the action belongs to.

Consent and signature do different jobs

Consent and approval authorize the tax-information process. A signature certifies the application information. Completing either one doesn't establish that you've completed the other.

The 2026-27 guide explains why this matters after filing. A correction can require another signature even though the contributor already gave consent and approval for that cycle. The correction needs certification; the existing cycle permission doesn't need to be collected again.

If a notice says a signature is missing, read it as a signature problem. Don't assume the tax permission failed. Equally, a signed page doesn't necessarily establish that the required tax approval exists.

That dated handbook also draws a firm boundary around helpers. Only the Department may collect consent and approval for this tax-information use. A school can help resolve a missing signature through the permitted process, but collecting that signature doesn't satisfy missing consent.

A counselor can explain a sentence. An advocate can sit beside you. One parent can remind another. None of them can supply the other contributor's consent on their behalf.

For your live application, check StudentAid.gov rather than looking for a button described in an older guide. The Department's current filing page says completion requires all required contributors to finish their sections, provide consent and approval, and sign. Finishing your own section is not necessarily finishing the family's form.

When the IRS cannot supply usable data

A failed retrieval isn't the same as a refusal to consent. Under the 2026-27 rules, an approved request can still produce no usable tax data.

The handbook describes IRS response codes on the **ISIR**, the Institutional Student Information Record. That's the application record used by the school. These are not code labels I'm claiming you'll see on a 2027-28 parent screen.

In the **2026-27** guide, code **200** means usable federal tax information was retrieved. Code **214** means the IRS located the individual but found no return on file for the relevant tax year. Codes

203, 206 and 212 mean the IRS could not provide usable information.

You don't need to memorize them. Knowing that the school has a record of the response lets you ask a more useful question than "Why is FAFSA broken?"

For the last group of codes, the 2026-27 guide requires that contributor to enter income and tax information manually. Those entries are used in calculating the Student Aid Index, but they are not considered verified merely because someone typed them. The Department or institution may require verification if the application is selected.

Manual entry is a route for supplying needed information when retrieval doesn't provide it. It isn't a route around required consent, and it isn't permission to guess.

Follow the current form's request and its tax-year instructions. If it asks for information you can't confidently identify, stop at that question and obtain the proper record or help. Don't interpret "no return on file" as proof that no filing obligation existed; ask a qualified tax preparer if that is genuinely uncertain.

Call the school's financial aid office when a retrieval problem, a manual-entry request or a verification notice leaves you unsure what documentation is needed. The office can inspect the school's record and explain its requirements. I cannot see those records from your kitchen table.

A useful opening is: "We're working on the 2027-28 FAFSA. This contributor supplied consent, but we're being asked for tax information manually. What should we check, and what documents do you need?"

Give the exact message if you have one. Send sensitive documents only through the secure method that office specifies. A pile of tax pages attached to an ordinary email is not my version of getting organized.

The SAI is not an invoice

SAI. Student Aid Index. A number, not a bill.

StudentAid.gov’s “What is the Student Aid Index?” explanation, checked on October 5, 2026, calls it an eligibility index used by a school’s financial aid office. It results from the information on the FAFSA.

The Department expressly distinguishes it from the aid amount you’ll receive, the amount your family is expected to provide and the final financial aid offer.

According to Federal Student Aid’s implementation letter GEN-23-11, the SAI replaced the Expected Family Contribution, or EFC. If an older handout uses that term, don’t treat the old label as a current instruction to pay.

An index doesn’t know whether your student has chosen a school. It isn’t that school’s invoice. When you eventually see it, keep its label attached. Don’t copy it into the household budget under “tuition owed.”

Chapter 7 explains the calculation and Pell eligibility. There is no guessed 2027-28 Pell amount here and no borrowed handbook example dressed up as your award. Check StudentAid.gov for the current award-year information. The school’s actual aid offer is a later document; Chapter 9 handles reading it.

For now, the useful distinction is between a missing action and a number you don’t like. A missing consent needs that contributor’s action. Disliking an index doesn’t tell you which answer, if any, is wrong.

The consent checklist, without tax amounts

Make one entry per required contributor for this FAFSA cycle. Leave passwords, Social Security numbers and tax figures off this working sheet.

1. Write the contributor's name and FAFSA cycle.
2. Record whether consent and approval were provided: yes, no or not yet confirmed. Add the date the contributor confirms the action.
3. Record the signature separately, then whether the required section is complete. Don't infer either from the consent entry.
4. For anything unresolved, write the exact action or question, who must handle it and when you'll check again.

On our pad, Vikram's entry first said "consent: no; return and read permission." Rohan's said "consent: yes." We didn't add tax amounts to prove those entries. We needed to locate an unfinished task, not recreate the return.

Choose a check-in time you can keep. It is your reminder, not an official processing deadline. If the current form gives different instructions or an action-required notice, follow those instructions instead.

Put the pad beside the laptop. Ask each required contributor about their own line.

Chapter 3: Divorced, Separated, Never Married

Gabe kept a custody calendar on the refrigerator. The children spent more nights at their mother's house, so he assumed she would be the parent on the FAFSA. It sounded settled. It wasn't.

The form does not use a calendar of overnight stays to choose between divorced parents. The Department's 2026-27 Application and Verification Guide assigns the parent role according to who provided more than half of the student's financial support during the preceding 12 months. That parent may not be the one the student lived with most. This is the 2026-27 rule; check StudentAid.gov for the instructions that apply to the live 2027-28 application. The form is available, but the matching handbook guidance has not been published as of October 5, 2026. I won't pretend a past-year rule is a confirmed future-year rule.

That distinction is the whole chapter. Residence tells you where the student slept. Support asks who paid more of the student's support over the period the handbook specifies. A parenting plan, a school address, and the name on a custody order may be relevant to your family, but they do not replace that federal test.

Start with the right question

When a student is dependent for federal aid purposes and the legal parents are divorced, separated, or never married and do not live together, the 2026-27 guidance measures financial support, not custody. The parent above the halfway mark in that 12-month period

is the one whose information goes on the form. StudentAid.gov's public parent-information page describes the distinction too. The page does not replace the missing 2027-28 handbook, so check the current instructions before using the rule to complete this year's application.

"More than 50%" means more than half, not exactly half. If you reach an equal split, neither parent provided more than half. The 2026-27 Handbook says that if neither parent provided more than half, the parent with the greater income and assets is the contributor. If neither parent supported the student financially, the same greater-income-and-assets fallback applies. Again: that is the 2026-27 rule. Confirm the current instructions rather than carrying it forward by instinct.

The comparison covers the last 12 months, not the parents' entire history. A divorce finalized years ago does not settle this year's support comparison. Neither does a parent's old tax return, a past child-support arrangement, or a pattern from the previous school year. Build the answer from the period the applicable instructions name.

The form's live 2027-28 materials also make one timing point plain: marital status is reported as of the day the FAFSA is filled out or signed, not projected into the future. StudentAid.gov's 2027-28 filling-out guidance, checked October 5, 2026, says the form asks for current marital status and directs families whose status changed since the tax return to its current instructions. Don't mark "divorced" because a divorce is expected next month, or "married" because you hope to reconcile. Answer the question as it stands on the date the form asks you to answer it.

Make a support record, not a custody argument

Parents often arrive with different kinds of proof. One has the calendar. The other has bank statements. One remembers paying for the braces; the other remembers the monthly transfer. Start by laying out the same 12-month period for both parents, using the date range stated by the current StudentAid.gov instructions. Don't silently substitute a calendar year or a school year.

Make a private worksheet with one column for each parent. List the support payments you can identify and document: direct payments for the student's needs, transfers, and amounts paid under an arrangement such as child support. If a bill was shared, write down how you assigned each parent's part. If one payment appears in more than one record, count it once. The worksheet is a way to make your comparison legible; it is not a Department worksheet or a substitute for the official instructions.

For 2026-27, the Department's Application and Verification Guide says child support and alimony paid count on the payer's side of this comparison. That can surprise a parent who thinks of a transfer only as money arriving in another household. Record it once, not once as a payment and again as a shared bill. This is not confirmed for 2027-28; verify the current instructions before making the comparison.

Write down what you know and what you don't. A canceled check, payment history, receipt, or shared-expense record can make a disputed figure easier to discuss. Don't invent precision where the records won't support it. The goal is a good-faith comparison under the official rule, not a spreadsheet that looks impressive.

Keep the notes plain enough that another adult could follow them. Put the date range at the top. For each entry, record the amount, who paid it, what it covered, and where you found the record. If a payment covered several people in the household, don't assign the entire amount to the student without a basis. Mark the uncertainty

and ask the aid office how it wants that situation documented. The public summary of the rule does not provide a complete household-accounting method, so this worksheet should organize evidence, not manufacture a formula.

You do not need to turn this into a courtroom exhibit before you can ask a question. A short, dated list and copies of the records that support it are often easier for an aid office to review than a long argument about which parent did more. Keep private financial documents secure, and send them only through a method the school confirms. If the other parent will not share records, write down what you have and what remains unknown rather than filling the gap with a guess.

The support-test worksheet

1. Confirm which parent situations the current StudentAid.gov instructions cover and the exact 12-month period they specify.
2. For each parent, list support you can identify for that same period. Note the source for each entry.
3. Include child support and alimony paid on the payer's side when applying the 2026-27 Handbook rule; check StudentAid.gov for 2027-28 treatment.
4. Compare the two totals. If one parent provided more than half, the 2026-27 rule points to that parent. If the totals are equal, or neither parent provided more than half, the 2026-27 fallback compares income and assets.
5. Save the records and the method you used. If the result depends on a disputed legal or financial fact, pause and ask the school's financial aid office what documentation it needs.

That final step matters. A worksheet can organize facts. It cannot decide a contested legal question for you.

Why the nights can point the wrong way

Gabe's custody calendar showed the children at their mother's home most nights. He thought that made her the FAFSA parent. When he compared the financial support each parent had provided during the period named in the 2026-27 instructions, the result was different from the calendar. His first answer had been tidy. It was also based on the wrong measure.

The point isn't that overnight stays never matter in family life. They matter a great deal there. The point is that the federal form's parent test is not a custody test. If the student sleeps at one home and the other parent pays a larger share of support, the support rule can point to the second parent. If that feels counterintuitive, return to the exact question: who provided more than half of the support in the applicable period?

Do not let a decree answer a question it was not written to answer. A custody order may establish parenting time or support obligations. It does not, by itself, decide which parent meets the federal aid test. The 2026-27 Handbook names support as the deciding measure. Check the current StudentAid.gov guidance for 2027-28 before you file, especially if your circumstances do not fit the plain example.

The second household can matter too

The parent selected under the support test may have remarried. That does not make the new spouse the student's legal parent, and a stepparent who has not adopted the student cannot stand in as the only parent. But the 2026-27 Handbook says a parent's spouse may still be required to provide information in certain situations. It identifies a remarried parent who did not file a joint tax return with the current spouse for the base year, and an unmarried parent living with the student's other legal parent. Those are 2026-27 handbook rules; check StudentAid.gov for the live year's directions.

This is where families can get tangled: “Who is my parent?” and “Who else must contribute?” are related questions, but not the same one. First identify the parent under the applicable rule. Then follow the form’s prompts about that parent’s current spouse or household. Don’t invite every adult who has ever helped with a bill, and don’t leave out a person just because they are not the student’s biological parent. Use the StudentAid.gov “Who’s My FAFSA Parent?” tool and the current parent-information instructions when the household does not fit a simple two-home picture.

If the parents were never married to each other but live together, the 2026-27 Handbook says both biological or adoptive parents provide information. A household can be unmarried and still be one shared household for this purpose. “Never married” alone does not tell you to choose one parent. The living arrangement matters under that year’s guidance. Confirm the live 2027-28 instructions before applying this detail.

If one parent has died, the 2026-27 Handbook says the student remains dependent on the surviving biological or adoptive parent, rather than a stepparent who supports the student, unless that stepparent adopted them. The handbook also says a grandparent or other relative raising a student is not a parent for this purpose unless the relative adopted the student. These are sensitive situations, and I won’t flatten them into a quick rule for 2027-28 without its published handbook. Check StudentAid.gov and contact the school’s financial aid office if the student’s legal relationship or family history makes the answer unclear.

When the answer is disputed

Sometimes the parents disagree about the amount of support. Sometimes the legal documents use “custodial parent” in a way that sounds decisive. Sometimes an agreement says one parent is

responsible for expenses while the records show a different pattern. These are not reasons to choose the answer that feels fairest, or to let the student referee a dispute between adults.

Use the current StudentAid.gov guidance first, then bring the records and the exact point of disagreement to the school's financial aid office. The office can explain what documentation it needs to process the application. It cannot rewrite a family-law order, and this book cannot interpret one. If a decree, support order, or contested payment obligation is central to the answer, speak with a family law attorney about the legal document and a tax or financial professional only if the records themselves need help. The FAFSA question remains governed by the current federal instructions; the attorney's role is to explain your legal situation, not to invent a different federal test.

There is a practical line between uncertainty and a legal dispute. If the parents simply need to assemble receipts and agree on arithmetic, do that together if it is safe and workable. If they disagree about what an order requires, whether a transfer was support, or what the records mean, don't ask the student to settle it at the kitchen table. Get the school's written guidance about the FAFSA documentation, and professional legal advice about the order.

The date on the form is not a prediction

Marital status can change between a tax return and the day the FAFSA is completed. The live 2027-28 StudentAid.gov guidance, checked October 5, 2026, says to report current marital status as of the date the form is filled out, and points to year-specific instructions when a parent's status changed since the tax filing. That is what the public 2027-28 guidance verifies; don't infer other form screens or unpublished handbook rules from it.

If a wedding, separation, or divorce is pending, don't answer based on the expected outcome. If the change already happened, don't assume the old tax return's filing status controls the current marital-status answer. Those facts may create separate questions about how financial information is entered. Chapter 2 covers consent and tax-data mechanics; this chapter stays with who is a parent and how the support test works. Follow the current 2027-28 help page for the changed-status situation, and ask the aid office before submitting if the instructions still don't fit.

Here's the move. Write down the period you're comparing, list each parent's support from records, and check the live StudentAid.gov parent guidance before deciding who to invite. Ten minutes to make the worksheet. More time if the records need it. If a custody order is colliding with the support rule, call a family law attorney instead of asking your student to pick a side.

Chapter 4: The Business and Farm Questions That Changed

Gabe caught me at the end of the driveway with a shoebox under one arm and a look I've seen across a front counter a hundred times.

"They count my business now," he said. "Somebody at the ballfield told me they count the business."

The box held invoices. Three years of them, rubber-banded by season, because he'd decided the only way to survive this question was to bring everything.

I asked him one thing first. Not what the trucks were worth. Not what he cleared last year.

"Who owns it, and how many people work for you?"

He blinked. "Me. And four guys, five in the spring."

"Then put the box down."

What actually changed, and when

Here's the part the ballfield rumor got half right. Something did change.

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act changed which businesses and farms have to be reported on the FAFSA, and the change took effect starting with the 2026-27 cycle. That's the Federal Student Aid Handbook's own framing of it, in the 2026-27 Application and Verification Guide, Chapter 2. Under that guidance, applicants report the net worth of a family business with **more than 100** full-time or full-time-equivalent employees, and the net worth of a farm the family does **not** live on.

Read that twice, because the rumor almost always drops the numbers.

The same 2026-27 guidance lists what stays off the form. A family business with **100 or fewer** full-time or full-time-equivalent employees that the family owns and controls. A farm where the family resides. A commercial fishing business owned and controlled by the family, along with its related expenses.

Gabe's landscaping company has five people in it during the busy months, counting Gabe. He owns it outright. Nobody else has a say in how it runs. Under the 2026-27 rules, that business is excluded, and the shoebox stays in his truck.

I need to be straight with you about something before we go further. I'm writing this while the 2026-27 handbook is the newest full edition the Department has published. The 2027-28 Application and Verification Guide wasn't out yet. So every rule in this chapter carries the year it came from. Before you answer the business or farm question on your student's form, check StudentAid.gov and the published guidance for your own award year. The form being live, as Chapter 1 confirmed, is not the same thing as published guidance explaining every rule behind it.

Don't let anyone, including me, tell you a prior year's threshold "will" hold. Look it up.

Why the old advice is half wrong, and the new rumor is worse

For years the shorthand was simple: small business, doesn't count, move on. Parents repeated it. Counselors repeated it. It was close enough to true that nobody got hurt.

Then the law moved, and the shorthand flipped in the other direction. Now the ballfield version is "they count businesses," which

sends a man with four employees to the mailbox holding three years of invoices he doesn't need.

Both versions skip the actual work, which is small. The exclusion didn't vanish. What changed is that it now rests on conditions a family has to check instead of assume: the employee count, and whether the family both owns and controls the thing. Two questions. Neither one takes an accountant to ask, though one of them can take an accountant to answer precisely.

Gabe's reaction is the one I want you to copy. Not the panic — the next part. He didn't report the business because somebody said to. He didn't skip it because somebody else said to. He checked the two tests, found he was excluded, and could say out loud *why*. If his form ever gets a second look from a school, he can explain his answer in one sentence. That's the whole goal here.

The two tests, in the order to ask them

Do we own and control it? The 2026-27 guidance ties the exclusion to a business the family owns and controls, which means more than holding a piece of paper with your name on it. If you're a minority partner in a company run by people you're not related to, or you hold shares in something you have no say over, you're outside what that exclusion describes. That's not a small business in the handbook's sense; that's an investment, and investments are Chapter 5's territory.

Where this gets murky is the middle ground. Family partnerships with cousins. An LLC where your brother-in-law holds forty percent. A business where your name is on the registration and your ex-spouse signs the checks. If you read "owned and controlled by the family" and genuinely can't tell whether that describes your situation, that's your signal to stop guessing. More on who to ask in a minute.

One wrinkle worth naming: “the family” here means the people whose information goes on this form, which is not always the people you’d list at Thanksgiving. If the contributor on your student’s form is one parent rather than two — the support test from Chapter 3 decides that — then the ownership question gets asked about that household, not about everyone related by blood. A business owned entirely by a parent who isn’t a contributor on this form isn’t that contributor’s asset to report. This is exactly the kind of tangle where an hour with the person who does the business’s taxes saves you a bad answer.

How many full-time or full-time-equivalent employees?

The 2026-27 handbook sets the line at more than 100 for reporting, 100 or fewer for the exclusion. If you have four employees, or nine, or thirty-one, you are nowhere near the line and you can stop counting.

If you’re somewhere close to 100, that phrase “full-time-equivalent” is doing real work and you shouldn’t improvise it. Part-time hours get combined into equivalents under rules that don’t live on StudentAid.gov. The person who prepares your business’s taxes already deals with employee counts for other federal purposes and is the right person to ask how yours comes out.

For a farm: do you live on it? The 2026-27 guidance excludes a farm on which the family resides and requires reporting a farm the family does not reside on. Families who farm one place and live in town are the ones this catches. If you inherited a half-section two counties over and nobody in your household sleeps there, that is not the same answer as the home place.

Commercial fishing? The 2026-27 guidance names commercial fishing businesses owned and controlled by the family, and the related expenses, as excluded. If that’s your family, read the current year’s guidance directly rather than taking my paragraph for it.

If you do have to report it, what the number means

Say the tests come out the other way and the business or the farm belongs on the form. The amount you enter is net worth, and the 2026-27 guidance defines that for investments the same way throughout: current market value minus the debt owed on it. If the result is negative, you report zero. The form does not want a loss, and you don't get credit for one.

Current market value is not what you paid. It is not the depreciated figure on a tax schedule. It is what the thing is worth right now, as of the day the form is signed, which is the point where guessing turns expensive in both directions.

Guess high and you hand the formula money your family doesn't have. Guess low and you've put a wrong number on a federal application your student signed. Neither one is where you want to be in April.

Debt means debt against that specific thing. The mortgage on the farmland comes off the farmland's market value. The note on the skid steer comes off the business. A credit card you've been living on, or the loan against your house, does not belong in this subtraction just because the money eventually went into the business. Keep the arithmetic attached to the asset.

And a reminder that saves families real money: the form asks for a snapshot. Net worth as of the day the application is signed, not an average, not last December. If the farmland is worth less this spring than it was last fall, the number you enter is this spring's, with the documentation to match.

The call to make

This is the chapter where I stop being useful, and I'd rather say so than pretend.

Valuing a business or a farm is a professional job. Not a kitchen-table job, not a Saturday-morning-with-a-spreadsheet job. If your answer to the two tests is “report it,” or if your answer is “I honestly can’t tell,” call the CPA or the tax preparer who already does the business’s or the farm’s returns. They have the balance sheet, the depreciation schedules, the loan balances and the employee counts in front of them. Ask them for a current market value and the outstanding debt against it, in writing, with the date they prepared it. Ask what they charge first; this is paid help, unlike the school’s aid office.

Keep that document. If the form gets selected for review, a dated valuation from the person who does your books is a far better answer than your memory of a conversation.

And if the question is legal rather than financial — whose business it even is, after a divorce or a death — that’s an attorney’s question, not your tax preparer’s.

What if you already answered, and now you think you got it wrong? Don’t sit on it. A submitted FAFSA can be corrected, and a parent who reported a business that the guidance excludes has been handing the formula an asset the family shouldn’t have been charged for. Go back into the form on StudentAid.gov, fix the answer, and resubmit. If you can’t work out how, call the school’s financial aid office before you start clicking. That office sees corrections every week, it’s free, and it would rather talk you through one now than untangle it after an offer goes out.

The same goes in the other direction, and it’s the less comfortable conversation. If you suspect you omitted an asset, check the 2027-28 form’s current guidance and ask the school’s aid office what correction is needed; the farm-residence and employee-count examples above come from 2026-27, not confirmed 2027-28 guidance. A correction you made is a different thing entirely from an error a school found.

What else stays off, regardless

While we're in the exclusions, the 2026-27 guidance also keeps several things off the asset question entirely, and these come up constantly whenever a family starts inventorying what they own.

Personal possessions. The family's principal place of residence — the house you live in. Retirement plans: 401(k)s, pension funds, annuities, non-education IRAs, Keogh plans. The cash value or equity of whole life insurance. ABLE accounts.

One catch inside that list, and it's the one people trip over: distributions from retirement plans do count as income under the same 2026-27 guidance. The account balance is excluded. Money you pulled out of it is not. If you took a withdrawal in the tax year the form uses, it is in your tax data and it will show up.

Chapter 5 takes the rest of the asset questions, including education savings accounts and rental property, and covers the circumstance where a family isn't asked about assets at all. Don't pre-answer those here.

The business and farm test

Apply this four-question test only to the 2026-27 handbook rules described above; before answering a 2027-28 FAFSA business or farm question, use the current StudentAid.gov form help and obtain school guidance for any uncertain ownership or valuation. Under 2026-27 guidance, the answers were:

1. Do we own **and** control this business? If no, it isn't covered by the small-business exclusion — treat it as an investment and see Chapter 5.
2. Is the employee count over the 2026-27 threshold described above? If yes, report its net worth. If no, and we own and control it, that guidance excludes it.

3. Is this a farm we live on? If yes, excluded. If we don't live on it, report its net worth.
4. Is this a commercial fishing business we own and control? If yes, excluded, including the related expenses.

Under every one of those, write the same two lines: the year of the guidance you checked, and the date you checked it. Mine for this chapter say 2026-27 and October 2026. Yours should say whatever the published guidance for your student's award year says on the day you look.

If any answer is "report it" or "I don't know," that's the CPA call, not a second opinion from the internet.

Gabe put the shoebox back in his truck and stood there a second, slightly deflated, the way people get when a thing they'd braced for turns out to be four questions.

"That's it?"

Four employees, five in spring. Owns it, runs it, excluded. He checked. Next time somebody at the ballfield tells him the rules changed, he'll be the one who knows which part.

Chapter 5: 529s, Rentals, Crypto and the Assets Nobody Thinks to Report

A family I worked with years ago spent an entire Sunday afternoon arguing about a 529 plan. Not whether to contribute to it. Whether to tell the FAFSA about it at all.

The grandmother had opened it. The mother managed it. The student was the one it was for. Three people, three plausible answers to “whose asset is this,” and not one of them had actually opened the Application and Verification Guide to check.

This chapter is the one where that kind of argument gets settled by a rule instead of a vote. None of what follows is about whether to save for college, or how, or how much. That’s a different book, and this one doesn’t pretend to be it. What follows is only about what the form wants you to report once the saving has already happened.

The 529 question, answered once

Under the 2026-27 Application and Verification Guide, a 529 or Coverdell owned by a parent and designated for this dependent student is reported as a parent asset; an account designated for another child is not included. If a grandparent is the owner and the student is only its named beneficiary, do not report it as the student’s or parent’s asset under that guidance.

Read that twice, because it contains two tests, not one. Designation decides which child the account belongs to: an account someone opened for the student’s younger sibling, or a cousin, or “whoever ends up going to college,” is not reported on this student’s

form just because it exists in the same family. Ownership decides whether it lands on the form at all.

The ownership half matters more than people expect. If a grandparent or another non-parent owns the account and the student is only the beneficiary, it is not reported as this student's or the parent's asset under the 2026-27 guidance. If a parent owns the account and designated it for this dependent student, report it as a parent asset. That single distinction ends more Sunday-afternoon arguments than almost anything else in this chapter.

It also explains why the family above spent an afternoon arguing past each other. The grandmother was asking an ownership question. The mother was asking a management question. Only the ownership question turns out to matter here.

One line, because this book's scope stops here: this is a reporting rule, not a planning tip. Whether to put a 529 in a grandparent's name, a parent's name, or restructure one before a student applies is a conversation for a financial planner who knows your family's full picture, not something I'll walk you through. Check StudentAid.gov for how this treatment applies to the year your student is actually filing.

UGMA and UTMA: the minor's money, the minor's asset

A UGMA or UTMA account works differently from a 529, and families sometimes assume the two behave the same way because an adult set both of them up. They don't.

Under the 2026-27 guidance, a UGMA or UTMA account is the minor's asset, not the custodian's, regardless of who manages it or who contributed the money. If your student has one of these accounts in their name, it gets reported as the student's asset on the student's side of the form, not folded into the parents' numbers. That

distinction can matter for the arithmetic in ways this book won't calculate for you until Chapter 7, but the reporting rule itself is simple: it's the child's name on the account, so it's the child's asset here.

Rental property: the door matters

Families who rent out part of their own home often aren't sure whether that counts as an investment at all, since it doesn't feel like the kind of asset the form seems to be asking about.

The 2026-27 guidance draws the line at the unit, not the arrangement. A portion of the home with its own entrance, its own kitchen and its own bath, rented to someone outside the family, is reportable rental property. A bedroom rented to a boarder who shares the kitchen and bathroom with the household is not. The test is physical and specific: can that part of the house function as its own home, separate from the rest of yours, and is the person living there not part of your family.

If you rent out a basement apartment with a lockable door, its own stove and its own shower, report it as an investment under the 2026-27 rule. Then value it carefully, because this is where families overreport. For a qualifying rental unit within your home, first calculate the net value of the entire structure. Then multiply that amount by the fraction represented by the rented unit. Report that portion, not the whole structure's net value. Ask the school's aid office or a CPA if you cannot document the fraction.

Net value of the whole structure means the same thing it means everywhere else on this form: current market value minus the debt against it, floored at zero if the subtraction goes negative. The prorating comes after that subtraction, not before it. And the fraction has to be something you could defend to an aid officer who asks:

square footage is the usual basis, documented once and kept with the rest of your filing paperwork.

If you rent a spare room to a graduate student who eats breakfast at your table and shares your hallway bathroom, that income may belong elsewhere on your tax return, but it isn't this kind of reportable asset.

The test doesn't care whether the arrangement is informal or whether a lease exists on paper. It cares whether the space itself could stand alone as someone else's home.

Virtual currency: priced the day you file

Bitcoin, Ethereum, and other virtual currency are investments for FAFSA purposes, and the 2026-27 guidance values them in US dollars as of the day the form is completed, not the day you bought them and not some average over the year.

That one detail trips families up because it feels unfair in both directions. A holding that's up sharply the week you file gets reported at that inflated number, with no averaging to soften it. A holding that's cratered gets reported low, with no credit for what you paid. The form wants a snapshot, the same way it wants a snapshot of every other investment, and crypto doesn't get a different rule just because the number moves faster. Price it the day you sit down to file, write down where you got the price, and move on.

Child support received: an asset, not income, and it adds up across the year

Here's the one that surprises almost every parent who receives it. Child support received is reported as an asset of the recipient, not as income, and the 2026-27 guidance has you total it across every child

in the family for the last complete calendar year, then enter the total once.

Parents who've been thinking of the monthly deposit as grocery money and school-supply money are sometimes startled to see it land on the asset side of a federal form rather than the income side. It changes nothing about whether you're entitled to it or how you spend it. It changes where this particular form counts it, and that's worth knowing before you're staring at the screen wondering which box it belongs in.

If you're receiving support for more than one child and the family size on this form includes all of them, add the full year's total together rather than reporting one child's share. The number the form wants is the household total for the calendar year the instructions specify, not a per-child breakdown.

Contested ownership: when you genuinely can't report a number

Separated and divorcing couples sometimes own something jointly that neither one can sell or borrow against without the other's agreement, and the dispute over it hasn't resolved by the time the FAFSA is due.

Under the 2026-27 guidance, an asset whose ownership is contested in that way, where you can't sell it, borrow against it, or otherwise access its value because of the dispute, is not reported while the dispute stands. That's a narrow exception, built for a specific kind of standoff, not a general escape hatch for anything uncomfortable to value. A house you co-own with an ex-spouse who's refusing to sign off on a sale or refinance is the kind of situation this covers. A business you'd simply rather not think about valuing is not.

And here's the part that catches people later: if the dispute resolves after you've filed, whether through a settlement, a court

order, or the other party finally agreeing, the 2026-27 guidance does not let you go back and update the value on that FAFSA. The snapshot was taken when it was taken. If the resolved value matters to a later award year's form, it belongs there, filed fresh, not grafted onto an application you already submitted.

If you're in the middle of exactly this kind of standoff, this is worth a conversation with the attorney handling the separation, not a guess at the kitchen table about how to answer the question.

The exemption that skips the asset questions entirely

Some families don't answer any of the asset questions in this chapter, because the 2026-27 Application and Verification Guide exempts them from the asset section altogether.

A dependent student qualifies for this exemption if the parents' base-year combined adjusted gross income is under \$60,000 and they filed no Schedule A, B, D, E, F or H. A Schedule C is allowed only if it shows a gain or loss no larger than \$10,000. The exemption also applies if the student qualifies for a Maximum Pell Grant on income alone. It applies as well if the student or a parent received a qualifying means-tested federal benefit in either of the two relevant calendar years. Those thresholds and the AGI figure are 2026-27 numbers specifically. Check StudentAid.gov before assuming they carry forward to the year your student is filing.

Three separate doors into the same exemption, in other words. A family only needs to walk through one of them, though one exception closes all three for certain households.

The 2026-27 guide makes an exception: a dependent student is **not** exempt from asset reporting if the parents live outside the U.S. or do not file taxes in the U.S. or a U.S. territory. Nonfiling because income is below the filing threshold is the exception to that

restriction. If this describes your family, ask the aid office what your current-year form requires.

The benefits that trigger that third path, under the same 2026-27 guidance, are the earned income credit, federal housing assistance, free or reduced-price school lunch, Medicaid, the refundable credit for coverage under a qualified health plan, SNAP, SSI, TANF and WIC. Receiving any one of them at any point during either of the two years the instructions specify is enough to qualify. You don't need to have received all of them, and you don't need to have received the same one both years.

One item on that list carries a condition most parents miss. For free or reduced-price school lunch, a meal provided through a schoolwide community-eligibility program does not by itself qualify you to check this benefit: under the 2026-27 guide, the household must also meet the USDA income eligibility guidelines. Verify your own award-year instructions before claiming this path.

That distinction matters because community eligibility covers whole schools, not individual households. A family whose child eats free lunch every day because the school qualifies as a building, not because the family qualifies on income, has not met this test. If you aren't sure which applies to your school, the district's food services office can tell you in one phone call.

If one of these applies to your family, it's worth knowing before you sit down to the asset section, because it can mean skipping a set of questions that otherwise cost families the most back-and-forth. It's also worth confirming on StudentAid.gov rather than assuming from memory, since both the AGI figure and the benefit list are exactly the kind of detail that gets revisited from one award year to the next.

The asset sort

Work through each asset you're not sure about, one at a time, and sort it into one of three piles.

- 1. Reported under the 2026-27 AVG (check the 2027-28 form's current help before filing):** A parent-owned education savings account designated for this dependent student; the student's UGMA/UTMA; a qualifying separate rental unit, prorated from the home's net value; virtual currency valued on filing day; and child support received for the calendar year specified by the form.
- 2. Excluded under the 2026-27 AVG, subject to the current 2027-28 form instructions:** An account designated for a sibling; a non-parent-owned education savings account with this student only as beneficiary; a bedroom sharing the family's kitchen and bath; or a genuinely contested asset the reporting contributor cannot access. Ask the aid office before omitting an uncertain asset.
- 3. Ask the school, or check whether the exemption applies.** Anything that doesn't sit cleanly in the first two piles belongs here. So does a rental fraction you can't document. So does free lunch you received through a schoolwide program rather than on household income. So does any household where a parent lives abroad or files no U.S. or territory return. And so does anything where your family's income sits close enough to the exemption's base-year AGI figure that it's worth checking before you fill out asset questions you might not need to answer at all.

Most families find that nearly everything they own sorts cleanly into the first two piles once they know the actual tests instead of the family folklore about them. The third pile is small, on purpose. It's

where the genuinely unclear cases belong, and it's smaller than most parents expect walking in.

The family from the start of this chapter never needed the third pile. Once they knew ownership was the only question that mattered, the grandmother's account sorted itself, and the argument that had eaten an afternoon took about ninety seconds to settle on a Tuesday night.

Ten minutes. Tonight. Pull up whatever you own that doesn't obviously belong to the house or the retirement account, and sort it against this list before you ever open the form. Write down the source for each answer — the handbook, the StudentAid.gov page, the date you checked — the same habit Chapter 4 asked of you for the business and farm questions. It takes less time than the argument it prevents.

Chapter 6: Family Size, Who's Independent, and the Number That Isn't There Anymore

Rohan pulled another chair toward the kitchen table, then stopped. Anika was at her apartment near campus. We didn't need the chair. We did need to think about her when we counted our family.

"So next year there are two of us in college," he said. "That helps, right?"

I wanted to give him the answer he expected. Two tuition bills ought to be noticed somewhere. But noticing a fact and automatically lowering an aid index are different things.

According to the Department's **2026-27 Federal Student Aid Handbook**, the number of family members in college is collected on the FAFSA but isn't used to calculate the Student Aid Index. SAI, for short. The sibling discount you may remember is not part of that edition's formula.

The **2026-27** edition of the Application and Verification Guide supplies the administrative rules, through its chapters "Filling Out the FAFSA Form" and "Special Cases." Check [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov) for your 2027-28 application. I haven't inspected authenticated family-size or dependency screens; I won't invent their wording or click order.

Count people, not chairs

In the 2026-27 guide, family size starts with information from the tax return: the filers plus the dependents, described there as the number of exemptions. This is a count of people, not a tax deduction you're being asked to calculate.

For online applicants whose required tax permission is supplied and whose information transfers successfully, that handbook describes a shorter task. Family size is derived from the transferred information. The applicant is asked whether the size differs from the tax-return count; a change leads to a follow-up asking for the number of dependents.

Those are **2026-27 mechanics**, not a verified description of your 2027-28 screen. Use the current question's help. The tax-transfer explanation from Chapter 2 supplies the background.

Somebody may have joined the household since the return. A child may no longer meet the support conditions. Don't answer "unchanged" merely because the income information arrived automatically. Read the current family-size instructions, then compare.

For a dependent student's family, the 2026-27 guide includes the student, the relevant parent and that parent's spouse or partner as applicable. The parent selection from Chapter 3 comes first; family size is not an invitation to add the other household back in.

That edition also includes the parent's dependent children who meet its residence and support conditions. A qualifying temporary absence, including living away for college, does not by itself exclude a child. The required parental support is more than half during **July 1, 2026, through June 30, 2027**, the period named in that handbook. Other people must live with the parent and meet the guide's support requirements for the entire award year.

Those dates belong to **2026-27**. Check StudentAid.gov for your application's support period and inclusion rules. Don't shift a date

forward and call it verified.

Anika's empty chair therefore wasn't the deciding fact. The relevant questions were whether her absence qualified and whether she met the applicable support test. "She's away at college" isn't a reason, by itself, to erase her. Nor is "she's our daughter" a substitute for checking the conditions.

Two students do not divide the index

Family size still matters in the **2026-27** SAI rules. The guide's chapter on SAI and Pell eligibility identifies it as an input. Number in college does not perform that same role.

Write this beside your notes: **family size and college attendance are separate facts.**

Don't divide an index between siblings and call the result their revised aid eligibility. The 2026-27 formula doesn't do that. Nor should you skip a required college-attendance answer because it doesn't change the calculation.

For the attendance count, the **2026-27** guide includes the student and qualifying family members enrolled at least half time in a degree or certificate program at a school eligible for federal student aid. A college sweatshirt doesn't establish enrollment. Check StudentAid.gov for the current definition before counting someone.

The same 2026-27 guide says schools may use the information in a special-circumstances adjustment. Its "Special Cases" chapter specifically names additional family members enrolled in college as a circumstance an administrator may consider. A review is a school decision about documented circumstances, not an automatic sibling reduction.

If overlapping college costs make the family's finances hard to explain, ask the aid office about its current review process and

required records. Don't promise either child an increase. Use Chapter 10 for the review packet, not a home-made sibling division.

For 2027-28, check StudentAid.gov and the school's current instructions.

Independent is an aid category, not a compliment

Your student may pay their own phone bill and resent being called dependent. For federal aid, dependency status tells the application whose information is required.

StudentAid.gov's public "Dependency Status" page, checked **October 5, 2026**, explains that dependent students report student and parent information. Independent students report their own information and, where applicable, a spouse's. Dependency does not order a parent to pay tuition.

The tax question is separate. That same Department page says living away from parents or not being claimed on their return does not, alone, establish independence. According to the **2026-27** handbook, reaching age **18 or 21** also does not do it by itself.

You cannot choose an aid status by deciding not to claim your student at tax time. Don't alter a return on the strength of this book. Use the IRS's current guidance or a qualified tax preparer for the tax question, and the current FAFSA instructions for the aid question.

A lease isn't a dependency override. A birthday cake isn't one either.

Rohan's age wasn't permission to skip the other tests.

The independence checklist, with its year attached

This is a **2026-27 checklist**, drawn from the Application and Verification Guide, not a set of answers to copy into 2027-28. Put yes, no or “needs checking” beside each item privately. Then compare with StudentAid.gov’s current “Dependency Status” page and your actual form.

1. **Birth date:** Was the student born before **January 1, 2003**?
That is the 2026-27 cutoff, not the cutoff for your current application.
2. **Marriage:** Is the student married, not separated, or remarried as of the application date under the 2026-27 rule?
3. **Graduate or professional study:** Will the student be a graduate or professional student during the award year covered by the 2026-27 guide?
4. **Active duty:** Is the student currently serving in the U.S. armed forces for a purpose other than training?
5. **Veteran status:** Does the student meet that year’s definition of a U.S. armed-forces veteran? Check the service and discharge conditions, not just whether they wore a uniform.
6. **Dependents of their own:** Does the student have children or other qualifying dependents, excluding a spouse, who satisfy the residence and support tests explained below?
7. **Childhood circumstances:** At age **13 or older**, were both biological or adoptive parents deceased, was the student a ward of a court, or were they in a qualifying child-welfare placement? Check the exact placement category on [StudentAid.gov’s dependency page](#), not an informal family arrangement.
8. **Court status:** Is the student, or were they upon reaching adulthood, a legally emancipated minor or in qualifying legal

guardianship established by a court? Guardianship by a parent or stepparent does not qualify under the 2026-27 guide.

9. **Housing circumstances:** Under the 2026-27 guide, was the student determined unaccompanied and homeless, or self-supporting and at risk of homelessness, at any time on or after **July 1, 2025**? Check StudentAid.gov for your application's date and determination process.

Read the Department's **2027-28** dependency questions directly. Don't modify this checklist from memory.

"Needs checking" is not a no. It means there's a fact to resolve.

A child isn't automatically a qualifying dependent

For **2026-27**, the handbook requires more than being a parent. The child or other dependent must meet its living-arrangement condition, currently receive more than half their support from the student and continue receiving that support during the specified award-year period. A child's qualifying temporary absence can count; a spouse doesn't count as this kind of dependent.

The source of support matters. The 2026-27 guide says that support supplied directly or indirectly by the student's parents cannot be relabeled as the student's own support to the child. If grandparents pay the household expenses, don't attribute every payment to the student just because the child lives there. Other support sources have their own treatment in that guide.

If this criterion determines independence, bring the support arrangement to the aid office. Don't borrow the divorced-parent comparison from Chapter 3.

Read the court document, not the family shorthand

For **2026-27**, the guide requires a court determination for emancipation or qualifying guardianship. It distinguishes

guardianship of the student's person from guardianship of an estate. If a document says custody rather than guardianship, the handbook directs the student to the aid administrator for guidance.

Court terminology and the basis for emancipation vary by state. Don't assume a relative's description proves the category. Let the school's aid office review the order under the applicable federal guidance; if the order's legal meaning is disputed, consult a family law attorney in your state and ask about fees first.

For childhood care history, find the agency or court records that identify the placement. A stay with a family friend is not, by itself, proof that the form's care criterion is met.

When contacting a parent isn't possible or safe

An unusual circumstance is not the same as a parent disliking a financial question. The **2026-27** "Special Cases" chapter describes dependency overrides where the student cannot contact a parent or contact would put the student at risk. It identifies circumstances such as abandonment, estrangement and incarceration for individual review.

A **dependency override** is the aid administrator's decision to treat an otherwise dependent student as independent because of qualifying unusual circumstances. It is not a status the student can declare final without review.

The **2026-27** guide describes provisional independence for students indicating unusual circumstances. They can proceed without parental data, but the provisional calculation does not finish the process. That edition says the application remains rejected pending the aid administrator's action. A provisional SAI is not an approved award.

Check StudentAid.gov for the reporting instructions. Ask the aid office for its unusual-circumstances procedure and a safe way to

communicate. Don't contact an unsafe parent to make this application look ordinary.

The 2026-27 guide allows documentation that can include a documented interview with the administrator or information from an appropriate agency or professional. Ask what the office needs. Having no neat folder doesn't mean there is no route to a determination.

Housing has its own route. Under the **2026-27** guide, homelessness includes lacking fixed, regular and adequate housing; it isn't confined to sleeping outside. Temporary shared housing because there is nowhere else to go can qualify under its definitions. If the student lacks a determination from a listed authority, that guide requires the aid administrator to evaluate the situation case by case. Check StudentAid.gov for the current process. Don't turn "I have a roof tonight" into an automatic no.

Refusal is a different branch

If parents simply refuse to supply information, with no qualifying unusual circumstance, that doesn't establish independence. The **2026-27** handbook says parental refusal, not claiming the student for taxes and total student self-sufficiency do not justify an override, separately or together.

That guide does describe a possible **Direct Unsubsidized Loan only** route for a dependent student whose parents refuse the FAFSA or won't provide financial support. It requires school review and documentation; it isn't a full-aid substitute or a switch that creates independent status. No loan limit is printed here.

Under **2026-27** guidance, if parents won't sign a refusal statement, documentation from an appropriate third party is needed; the student's statement alone isn't sufficient for this branch. Ask the office what it accepts for your current award year.

Before anyone chooses this route, read StudentAid.gov's current explanation of applying only for an unsubsidized loan. Don't mistake it for an application for Pell and the rest of the federal aid package. If information can be supplied safely, understand what would be lost before leaving it out.

A graduate program changes the category

According to the **2026-27** handbook, graduate and professional students are independent for federal aid purposes and aren't eligible for Pell Grants. Check StudentAid.gov and the school for current eligibility; this chapter doesn't promise other aid in Pell's place.

Write down the student's actual program, not the degree they hope to pursue after finishing this one. If study changes during the award year, ask the aid office how the application should reflect it.

Here's the move. Mark the checklist's uncertain item, copy the current StudentAid.gov source beside it and send the aid office that specific question. Ten minutes to start. Leave room on the page for the answer.

Chapter 7: What Comes Out the Other End: the SAI and the Pell Grant

You finish the questions, close the tax papers, and wait for the part that sounds like an answer. Then a school or a federal aid notice gives you an SAI, and the natural question is: how much money is that?

It is not money. It is not a bill, a promise, or the amount your family is expected to write a check for. SAI means Student Aid Index. The number helps determine eligibility for federal student aid, including Pell Grant eligibility. A school then builds its own offer from the student's eligibility, the school's cost of attendance, and the aid available there. Keep those jobs separate, and the number becomes less mysterious.

The live 2027-28 FAFSA is available and StudentAid.gov says it asks for 2025 tax information. That is what the form's current guidance says. The separate eligibility guide supplies current SAI and Pell mechanics; the 2027-28 Application and Verification Guide and Volume 7 are still pending. Rules supported only by the older handbook remain labeled 2026-27. Match each rule to the correct award year before you use it.

One acronym, three paths

The Department's published [2027-28 SAI/Pell guide](#), Step 2, identifies three formulas for 2027-28. Formula A is for a dependent

student. Formula B is for an independent student without dependents other than a spouse. Formula C is for an independent student with dependents other than a spouse.

That is the map, not an invitation to calculate the number yourself. Chapter 6 covers how family size and dependency status enter the conversation. The school's calculation follows the student's status and the information reported; it isn't a worksheet where you can substitute one household's answers into another household's formula.

The letters are categories, not grades. A Formula C is not a better result than a Formula A, and a family does not select the formula it prefers. The student's status determines which path applies under the rules for that award year. If you are comparing an old SAI with a new one, first check that you are comparing the same kind of index for the right years. A prior result is useful history, not a promise that the next application will reproduce it. When a result surprises you, start by checking the submitted information and the current-year guidance; don't try to force the calculation to match last year's number.

A useful way to think about the inputs is a short list: income, assets, family size, dependency status, and state. The FAFSA questions collect information that the formula handles in a particular way. Chapters 4 and 5 explain what belongs in the asset answers under the guidance they cite. You do not need to reopen every asset decision here. If you are uncertain whether an item belongs on the form, go back to those chapters and verify the rule for your award year before submitting.

Chapter 6 separates family size from number in college. Here, use the family-size figure in the applicable formula; do not substitute a sibling count.

There is no reliable kitchen-table shortcut from a tax return to an SAI. The form takes several kinds of information, applies allowances

and formula steps, and produces an index. For 2027-28, the Department's Formula A worksheets apply 12 percent to parent discretionary net worth and 20 percent to the dependent student's net worth. That formula assesses the student's available income at 50 percent after allowances. Table A5 in the 2027-28 guide sets the parent contribution from adjusted available income on a scale from 22 to 47 percent.

Those percentages describe pieces of the machinery, not percentages of your whole paycheck or a direct estimate of your college bill. Don't multiply your savings by a rate and call the result your SAI. Don't try to reverse-engineer it from one line on a tax return. The Department published a separate 2027-28 Student Aid Index and Pell Grant Eligibility Guide in June 2026; use that guide for current SAI formulas, while checking StudentAid.gov for the as-yet-unannounced 2027-28 maximum Pell amount and awaiting the 2027-28 handbook. For 2027-28 SAI and Pell eligibility mechanics, consult the Department's published 2027-28 Student Aid Index and Pell Grant Eligibility Guide; the handbook AVG and Volume 7 are still pending. Let the official process do its job; use your time to check that the answers you gave were accurate.

A negative number is still a number

Federal Student Aid's 2027-28 guide sets the SAI floor at -1,500 in Step 2; a negative result below that boundary is raised to the floor. This is not a debt in reverse, a refund amount, or a promise that a school will send a check. It is an index result within that year's formula.

Under Step 1 of the 2027-28 guide, a dependent student whose required parents qualify as non-tax filers receives the nonfiler Maximum Pell indicator and an SAI of -1,500 without a formula calculation. Appendix D refers the tax-filer determination to the

FAFSA Specifications Guide; both required parents must qualify for this dependent-student pathway. Foreign-only filers or families with foreign income must check their own reporting rules with StudentAid.gov and the school; not filing a U.S. return by itself does not establish this status. For other income-qualified Maximum Pell recipients, the 2027-28 guide assigns the lower of zero or the calculated SAI. These are published 2027-28 mechanics, not an assumed carry-forward. Ask the aid office if your tax-filer status is unclear.

A low or negative index can matter for eligibility, but it does not name a grant amount. The distinction is worth keeping on the same page as the number. If someone says, “Your SAI is minus fifteen hundred, so your school will give you a particular amount,” stop there. That conclusion needs the Pell rules and figures for the correct award year, plus the school’s cost of attendance and its actual offer.

Pell eligibility has more than one gate

For undergraduate students who have not earned a bachelor’s, graduate, or professional degree, Pell eligibility is not determined by the SAI alone. Steps 1 and 3 of the Department’s 2027-28 eligibility guide describe Maximum and Minimum Pell income pathways using the family’s size, state and applicable poverty guideline.

The 2027-28 guide retains the dependent-student nonfiler pathway described above and provides separate income tests for tax filers. In Step 1, AGI plus the foreign income exclusion must be above zero and no greater than 225 percent of the applicable poverty guideline for a single-parent family. For other dependent families, the 2027-28 Maximum Pell threshold is 175 percent, with the same above-zero condition. Step 3 sets dependent-student Minimum Pell income limits at 325 percent for single-parent families and 275 percent for other families. Those 2027-28 Minimum Pell tests also

add the foreign income exclusion to AGI; qualifying students must additionally have an SAI below twice the annual Maximum Pell award. The guide's Appendix G determines single-parent status, rather than a family's informal description of itself.

These are 2027-28 percentages, not a dollar award or a promise of a school's offer. Step 1 uses the parents' state for a dependent student, with separate poverty-guideline categories for Alaska, Hawaii and Other. That detail matters. A current-year chart for the student's state may not be the chart or year the rule calls for. Do not turn the percentages into a dollar cutoff using a figure from a different year. The published 2027-28 SAI and Pell Grant Eligibility Guide specifies the 2025 HHS poverty guidelines and this cycle's income tests. Use that guide for eligibility mechanics; check StudentAid.gov for the still-unannounced 2027-28 maximum Pell dollar amount. Check StudentAid.gov for the applicable instructions, especially if the household's tax filing or family circumstances do not fit a simple example.

Graduate and professional students are independent for FAFSA purposes under the 2026-27 guidance and are not eligible for Pell Grants. Chapter 6 covers the dependency categories; the point here is narrower. Don't mistake an SAI calculation for a Pell decision when the student is outside Pell's eligibility rules.

The word "Maximum" can mislead. It names a limit set for an award year, not the amount every eligible student receives. The Department of Education says in Volume 7, Chapter 2 of its 2026-27 Federal Student Aid Handbook, that the maximum Pell amount is established for the award year and announced when available. No 2027-28 maximum or minimum dollar amount is stated here. A figure from another year, or a made-up worked example, would be the wrong tool for your budget.

How the calculated amount is shaped

Under 2026-27 Volume 7, subtract the SAI from the published maximum. If the result is less than the published minimum, there is no calculated Pell award; the student might separately qualify for Minimum Pell under its income tests. Otherwise round the calculated result to the nearest \$5 and cap it at the student's Pell cost of attendance. The minimum is 10 percent of the maximum for that award year, rounded to the nearest five dollars under the same 2026-27 guidance.

That explanation is a map, not a calculator. It needs the official maximum and minimum for the correct year, the official SAI, and the school's cost-of-attendance figure. The eligibility methodology is published, but StudentAid.gov's Pell page still lists only the 2026-27 maximum as checked October 5, 2026. With no announced 2027-28 maximum dollar award there, a numerical example would borrow an old amount or invent the missing one. Neither helps you.

Cost of attendance is the school's published estimate of the cost of attending, not a promise that the family will spend exactly that amount. In the calculation specified by the 2026-27 Volume 7, it acts as a cap on the calculated Pell award. It does not turn the SAI into a bill, and a Pell eligibility result does not by itself tell you what the full award letter will contain. Chapter 9 sorts those offer lines into grants, loans, and what remains for you to pay.

Two 2026-27 changes to check carefully

The Department's 2026-27 Pell volume describes two One Big Beautiful Bill Act changes. First, under that year's rule, a student's SAI at or above twice that year's maximum Pell amount makes the student ineligible for Pell. The guidance describes a narrow special rule for certain children of deceased servicemembers and public safety officers, so do not treat the cutoff as an exception-free rule.

Second, under 2026-27 Volume 7, nonfederal grants or scholarships meeting or exceeding cost of attendance ordinarily bar Pell; the Special Rule for eligible children of certain deceased servicemembers and public safety officers is exempt from this restriction too. Ask the school's aid office to assess a possible exception.

Both statements are deliberately labeled 2026-27. They are not a claim that the same thresholds or mechanics apply in 2027-28. Before using either to plan, read the current StudentAid.gov guidance. If an award or outside scholarship raises a question, call the aid office at the student's college. Its staff can explain how that school's offer is assembled; they cannot make an unpublished federal rule appear.

Read the number without making it carry too much

Put the SAI on one line. Beside it, write what it can tell you: it is an index used in aid eligibility calculations. On the next line, write what it cannot tell you by itself: your final grant, your school's offer, or the amount you will owe. That little separation prevents a number from turning into a verdict about whether college is affordable.

Here's the move. Make a page with five labels: tax year shown, asset answers to check, family-size response, dependency response, and state of legal residence. Under each, write only the source or answer you need to verify, not account passwords, Social Security numbers, or tax details. The FAFSA's live 2027-28 guidance says the form asks for 2025 tax information. Use the published guide linked above for current eligibility mechanics, not a wait for its release. Rules cited only to the 2026-27 handbook keep that older label.

When your result arrives, do not try to turn the index into a grant estimate in your head. Find the year's official Pell figures and rules at StudentAid.gov, then read the school's cost of attendance and offer.

If something in the family changed after the tax year on the form, the school may be able to review documented special circumstances; Chapter 10 explains how to ask. For an unclear calculation or eligibility result, call the financial aid office at the school your student is considering. A tax preparer or CPA can help untangle tax information, but only the school can explain its aid offer.

Try the interpretation exercise with your own result, not an invented sample. Copy the SAI from the official record and write beside it: “index used in aid calculations.” Then test three statements. “This is the amount we owe” — no. “This alone tells us the Pell award” — no. “The Pell decision depends on the rules and published figures for the same award year, and the school offer has its own cost-of-attendance context” — yes. If you cannot find the year’s official amount or rules, leave the calculation blank rather than borrowing a number from an old article. If the Department has not yet announced the 2027-28 maximum Pell dollar amount, leave that dollar calculation blank and check StudentAid.gov again.

The useful question is not “What will this number buy?” It is “What does this number establish, and what do I still need to verify?” Keep those on separate lines. Ten minutes. Tonight.

Chapter 8: The CSS Profile, and a Deadline Map With No Guessing

Somewhere between the SAI and the award letter, a second form shows up in your inbox. It has College Board's name on it instead of the Department of Education's. It asks for things the FAFSA never mentioned — home equity, a noncustodial parent's finances, sometimes a second set of tax forms. It arrives with its own login and its own password rules, and no explanation for why any of this is needed when you just finished one application.

That form is the CSS Profile, and it is not a federal form. It is not required everywhere. And the two most expensive words in this chapter are “check yourself,” because nearly everything about it — who requires it, what it costs, when it's due — is set by individual colleges and by College Board, a private organization, not by a government agency with one national rule.

Why some colleges want a second form

The FAFSA produces a Student Aid Index. The SAI is built from a formula Congress wrote, and it uses a defined, limited set of inputs: income, certain assets, family size, dependency status. It does not ask about home equity. It does not look past the parent the support test names in Chapter 3. For a public university working only with federal and state aid, that's enough.

Some private colleges — and a smaller number of public ones with their own institutional aid to hand out — want more detail before they decide how to spend their own money. The CSS Profile is

College Board’s way of collecting it: home equity, a noncustodial parent’s income and assets in many cases, and other specifics the federal formula skips entirely. College Board describes the Profile as the route to nonfederal aid at the colleges, universities and scholarship programs that use it (cssprofile.collegeboard.org, checked 2026-10-03).

College Board is a not-for-profit membership organization, not a federal agency. CSS Profile policies, fees, participation, and college-specific requirements can change, so check College Board and each college directly in the month you apply.

Four things you have to look up, not guess

This section won’t give you a number for any of these. The honest version of this chapter is a set of directions to someone else’s page, not a page of figures that might already be stale by the time you read it.

Does your college require it? Not every school that takes the FAFSA also wants the CSS Profile, and the list changes. College Board keeps a participating-institutions lookup; use it for every school on your list, every year, rather than assuming because a sibling applied there in 2023 that the requirement is unchanged (CB, “Check Participating Schools and Scholarships,” checked 2026-10-03).

Does a noncustodial parent have to file one too? Some colleges that use the Profile want financial information from both parents even after a divorce or separation. That requirement does not care who the support test in Chapter 3 names as the FAFSA parent; it is a separate, institutional question. College Board publishes guidance specifically for divorced or separated families, and a separate waiver-request form for situations where the noncustodial parent can’t or won’t take part (CB, “Divorced or

Separated Families,” checked 2026-10-03). Whether a waiver request is accepted at all is the college’s decision, not College Board’s and not yours to assume. If this is your situation, read that guidance for each school on your list. Don’t tell anyone a noncustodial-parent form “isn’t needed” on the strength of one school’s rule — it might be needed at one school and not another.

Is there a fee, and does a waiver apply? The Profile charges a fee per college. College Board states on its own fee-waiver pages that the application is free for some families under an income threshold it sets and can change (CB, “Fee Waivers,” checked 2026-10-03). I’m not printing that income number here, on purpose: it is College Board policy, not law, and policy moves. Open the fee-waiver page yourself, read the number that’s posted the month you apply, and write it down with the date you checked it — the same habit you used for the business and farm tests in Chapter 4.

When is it due? This is the one people get backwards most often. College Board doesn’t set Profile deadlines. Each college does, the same way each college sets its own FAFSA priority deadline. Two students applying to two different schools through the same CSS Profile account can be working against two completely different dates.

The deadline map has three layers, and only one of them is federal

Families walk into this expecting one deadline, the way a tax return has one. There are three, stacked:

The first is federal: the filing cutoff for your FAFSA award year. Availability tells you when you can start, not when you must finish. For the cycle this book covers, the 2027-28 FAFSA form is live now — I confirmed that directly on StudentAid.gov. What I’m not going to do is hand you a specific “you must file by” federal date. The

form's own guidance is the only place that date can be checked correctly for your situation, and I'd rather send you there once than print something here that's wrong by the time you read it.

The second layer is your state. Every state that offers its own grant aid receives FAFSA data and sets its own filing window for that aid. There are fifty different windows. Some are tied to a hard date; some run on a first-come basis until the money runs out. I can tell you the mechanism; I can't responsibly print all fifty dates in a book that has to be right a year from now. Find your state's higher education agency — a web search for “[your state] student financial aid agency FAFSA deadline” will get you there — and write its deadline into your own calendar, not this one.

The third layer is each school's own priority deadline, published on that school's financial aid website, sitting entirely outside the first two. This is the one that costs families real money when they miss it, and it has nothing to do with the federal government or College Board.

Why “priority” matters more than the deadline that sounds scarier

Schools usually publish two kinds of date. A school may set a final deadline for consideration for its own aid. Missing it can close that school's institutional-aid route, but it does not erase the separate federal FAFSA filing route. Check StudentAid.gov and the school to learn exactly what remains. A priority deadline is an earlier date that can matter when limited school or state funds are awarded before later applications are reviewed, which sounds softer and isn't. A lot of institutional and state aid is awarded on a first-come basis out of a limited pool. File after the priority date and the form can still be processed, and the student can still be considered for federal aid. But the pot of first-come institutional or state money may already be

committed to families who filed earlier. Nobody tells you that in a rejection letter; the money is just smaller, or the offer just doesn't include a line you expected.

I've watched this play out as a simple timing accident more often than as anyone doing anything wrong. A family files a complete, accurate FAFSA three weeks after a school's priority date, certain they're still "on time" because the final deadline is months away. The form processes fine. The aid office never flags an error. The offer that comes back is just thinner than a neighbor's, filed three weeks earlier for a similar income. Nobody calls that a mistake on the form. It's a mistake in the calendar.

That's a mechanism, not a sure thing in either direction. I'm not going to attach a probability or a dollar figure to "what happens if you miss it," because nobody publishes one that would still be true next year. What I will say plainly: treat a priority deadline as the real deadline. The final deadline is a legal cutoff. The priority deadline is where the money actually is.

Building one calendar instead of juggling three

Here's the system I actually use with families, and it only works because every entry comes from a source you looked up yourself that week, not from memory.

The three-deadline calendar. For every school on the list, one row, three columns. Federal confirmation: the form is open, with StudentAid.gov checked for anything year-specific. State deadline: named agency, date, the day you checked it. School priority deadline: named school's financial aid page, date, the day you checked it. No cell gets filled from a conversation with a neighbor, a forum post, or last year's letter. If a cell is blank because you haven't checked yet, leave it blank. A blank cell is honest; a guessed one isn't.

The deadline card belongs here, beside that calendar, not beside the account-making task. Use StudentAid.gov’s “FAFSA Deadlines” page at studentaid.gov/apply-for-aid/fafsa/fafsa-deadlines for the federal filing cutoff and state guidance. Confirm the particular state program with the agency that administers it. Get the school’s aid dates from its financial aid office, not its tuition page. A published price tells you what attendance costs; it doesn’t tell you when an application is due.

Give each entry a source URL and a checked-on date. Write the award year too. The verified availability note for this book is simply “2027-28 form available,” based on the Department’s public filing guidance checked October 5, 2026. It is not a deadline. If you haven’t obtained the actual federal cutoff, leave that separate field unresolved. Do the same for a state or school date you cannot verify. A page that won’t load doesn’t establish that no deadline exists.

For your state entry, record the program’s name rather than just “state aid.” For each school, specify whether the date concerns FAFSA submission, the CSS Profile or required supporting documents. Ask the issuing office about anything ambiguous. Keep its answer with the calendar instead of silently converting a vague instruction into a date you prefer.

Do this for the CSS Profile exactly the same way, school by school, since Chapter 8’s real lesson is that “the deadline” doesn’t exist as a singular thing anymore, if it ever did.

A submission time needs a time zone

College Board’s “Complete the Application” instructions, checked October 5, 2026, say the CSS Profile submission date and time are based on Eastern Time. That is a useful detail if your kitchen clock isn’t. Check the posted instructions again when you apply, then ask

each college how it interprets its cutoff. Don't assume a date on a college page means midnight wherever you happen to be.

Suppose the school's page gives a date but no hour. Copy the date without adding an hour yourself. Ask, "What time and time zone govern this CSS Profile deadline, and must the supporting documents also be received by then?" That's a request for the school's rule, not a request for an extension. Record the reply before building your reminder around it.

Set your own working date earlier than the verified cutoff, with enough room for the tasks you actually have left. That buffer is a household choice, not an official grace period. If the application needs a parent's information or a document held somewhere else, allow for that dependency rather than scheduling everyone to begin at the last possible moment.

I don't recommend a countdown that ends with the laptop battery warning. A reminder should get you to work while there is still time to ask a question. It should not celebrate how close you can come to being late.

The receipt is not the whole document job

College Board's application guide also says the CSS Profile dashboard includes a payment receipt and next steps, which may include uploading documents through the Institutional Documentation Service. IDOC, for short. Not every family has the same next step. Read what your actual application and colleges request rather than sending a tax folder somewhere because another parent did.

Treat the receipt as evidence of the transaction it records. It does not, by itself, prove that a college has every document needed for its aid review. A file uploaded to a requested service and a college

marking its requirement satisfied are different events. Keep your own notes distinct so you can ask about the actual missing piece.

If a college's official portal still lists something outstanding, open the requirement and read it before uploading another copy. Identify the requested document, the relevant year and the permitted submission route. If you've already supplied it, ask the office whether it is awaiting review or whether something different is required. Don't invent a normal processing interval from another college's experience.

A useful message is, "My CSS Profile was submitted, and I retained its receipt. Your aid checklist still shows this document as outstanding. I sent it through the requested route. Does it need further action, and which deadline applies?" Include the document's description and your submission date, not account credentials. Use the office's approved secure channel for any supporting financial records.

This is not an invitation to build a second application tracker with every FAFSA consent step on it. The account card in Chapter 1 and consent sheet in Chapter 2 already handle those jobs. Here you are tracking the extra institutional request: who asked for it, what they requested, where it belongs and whether that office has confirmed its status.

Share the research, not a guess

When more than one adult helps, split the CSS Profile lookup by school. One person can confirm a college's requirements while another checks a different college. Bring back the actual links and instructions, not "they want the same stuff." Two offices can use similar language and mean different document deadlines.

Assign the next action to a person who can do it. If the college requests a noncustodial parent's submission, your checking the

website doesn't complete that parent's task. If a waiver question remains, use that school's aid office rather than treating silence as acceptance. The federal parent-selection rule in Chapter 3 doesn't settle either institutional request.

After a school answers, update the specific unresolved entry. Keep the older note as history if it explains what you asked, but make the current instruction unmistakable. Nobody should have to choose between an old screenshot and a new email while trying to submit.

You are organizing evidence of requirements, not lobbying the calendar into agreement. A verified deadline can still be inconvenient. It is easier to plan around the inconvenient truth than around a reassuring date nobody actually published.

Starting the Profile the same week as the FAFSA

If any school on your list uses the CSS Profile, start it the same week you start the FAFSA, not after. The reasons are practical, not dramatic. The Profile asks questions the FAFSA doesn't, which means pulling documents you may not have gathered yet — home equity figures, a noncustodial parent's information if that's required at this particular school. If a noncustodial parent needs their own login and their own session, that parent needs to be told now, not two weeks before a priority deadline, especially if the relationship is strained enough that a conversation needs to happen first.

Starting both forms in the same week doesn't make either one shorter. It just means you find out what's actually required — a waiver request, a second parent's participation, a fee that may or may not apply to you — while there's still time to act on the answer, instead of finding out the week something is due.

One more plain fact before this chapter closes: nothing in the CSS Profile changes who the FAFSA names as the contributing parent

under the support test from Chapter 3. The two forms ask different questions for different purposes. A college that wants a noncustodial parent's information on the Profile is making its own institutional-aid decision. It isn't overriding the federal support test, and it can't be argued out of wanting what it wants.

If a particular school's noncustodial-parent requirement creates a genuine conflict — a custody situation, a parent who's unreachable or unsafe to involve — that conversation belongs with that school's financial aid office directly. It's the one office that can actually tell you what that school will and won't accept.

One more thing worth naming

Families sometimes assume a college that doesn't require the CSS Profile has no institutional aid to offer, or that a college requiring it is automatically more generous. Neither follows. A school's aid philosophy — how much of its own money it gives out, and how it decides who gets it — isn't visible from which form it collects. The Profile tells you what a school wants to know. It doesn't tell you what a school will do with the answer.

The same caution applies to the CSS Profile's own supplemental questions, which vary by college. One school might ask about a small business using its own worksheet instead of the **2026-27 handbook's** 100-employee small-business test discussed in Chapter 4; check current FAFSA instructions before treating that threshold as a 2027-28 rule. Another might ask about retirement account balances the FAFSA excludes outright. Read each college's specific Profile supplement before assuming the federal asset rules carry over — they don't automatically, and College Board's own help pages for that school are the place to check, not this book and not last year's experience with a different school.

If, after checking every one of your schools, none of them requires the CSS Profile, you can skip this entire process and the fee that comes with it. Don't fill it out because a well-meaning relative assumes everyone has to. Check the list first.

Chapter 9: What the Award Letter Actually Says

Anika slid the laptop across the table and pointed at the total. We had waited so long for her 2024-25 offers that anything with a number on it felt like relief.

I already had a folder of screenshots: application confirmations, messages sent, dates I had called each school. Her offers had arrived late in our experience. That is our family scene, not a measure of what happened to other applicants.

Then I read below the total. One offer included a Parent PLUS loan in the block labeled aid. Part of the apparent good news was money a parent would have to borrow.

I pulled a paper napkin out of the holder and drew two lines down it. Grants and scholarships. Loans. What we pay.

Anika looked at the last column. So did I.

The napkin wasn't a borrowing plan; it was a way to separate money that reduced the price from money that financed it before we decided what the offer meant for us.

Read the labels before the total

Federal Student Aid's "How To Evaluate Your Aid Offers," checked October 5, 2026, says there is no standardized format or delivery method for these offers. A school may send a document or present its information electronically. Don't expect the next school's layout to explain itself because you understood the first one.

The offer is the school’s statement of the types and amounts of aid available to your student there. It is not the eligibility index from Chapter 7. Start with the school document, its conditions and the period it covers.

Check whether each amount is for a term or the school year. Find the award year and any enrollment or housing assumptions. If those details are missing, write “not confirmed” and ask. Doubling a term amount or halving an annual one without evidence can make a sensible comparison useless.

Don’t let a bright total do the sorting. A block called “financial assistance” might contain grants, borrowing and potential work earnings. Federal Student Aid’s evaluation guide distinguishes money given, money earned and money borrowed. Use that distinction, whatever the school’s labels.

An unfamiliar award name stays outside your totals until you can classify it. Copy its full name into a question for the school. “Is this a grant, a loan, or something the student must earn?” is better than guessing from a benefactor’s surname.

Also notice words such as “estimated,” “tentative” or “pending.” StudentAid.gov’s “Comparing School Financial Aid Offers,” checked October 5, 2026, explains that tentative offers can change. Keep the conditions attached to the amount rather than copying only the number into your comparison.

The first column needs its small print

Grants and scholarships belong in the first column. Federal Student Aid’s financial aid dictionary, checked October 5, 2026, describes grants as funds that generally need not be repaid and scholarships as monetary gifts. These are the offer lines that can reduce what you must finance.

But “not a loan” doesn’t mean “no conditions.”

Read the award terms for enrollment requirements, eligible expenses and renewal conditions. If a scholarship has an academic requirement, copy the actual requirement. Don't supply a grade-point average from another school's policy.

Treat a missing renewal statement as a question, not permission to multiply the award across an entire degree when the document in front of you promises help for only the first year. Ask what the student must do to keep it, whether the amount stays fixed, and how long the award lasts. Save the answer.

There is a second distinction: losing future aid and having to return aid already paid are not identical outcomes. The award's terms decide some scholarship consequences. Federal grant rules require their own check.

The withdrawal volume of the Federal Student Aid Handbook explains the **2026-27** rule: leaving school can require unearned federal aid to be returned. Its overpayment guidance also describes circumstances in which grant funds already paid must be repaid. A change in enrollment can affect eligibility or the amount awarded; it does not automatically mean every grant becomes repayable.

Before your student drops courses or withdraws, ask the aid office what happens to the current award and the school-account balance. For **2027-28**, check StudentAid.gov and ask the school to identify the applicable guidance. Do not calculate a return from the previous year's handbook or assume the school's tuition-refund policy settles the federal-aid question.

Keep those terms.

The loan column belongs to a borrower

Write each loan in the middle column, with the borrower beside it. A Direct Subsidized Loan and a Direct Unsubsidized Loan are borrowing, not grants. The word "subsidized" doesn't move a loan

into the gift column. Chapter 11 handles their differences; here, both stay under debt.

Parent PLUS needs an especially clear label. Federal Student Aid's offer-evaluation page states that the parent, rather than the student, is responsible for repaying a parent PLUS loan. Write "parent borrower" next to that line. Don't let its placement under your child's name erase whose obligation it would be.

The Parent PLUS line on our napkin moved out of the money-given column. The offer itself hadn't changed. Our reading had.

Borrowing can help cover a bill, but it doesn't make the education cheaper. Interest is an additional cost of borrowing, as Federal Student Aid's dictionary explains. Keep that future obligation separate from the current school-account balance.

Ask whether a suggested loan line is an actual offer requiring acceptance, an estimate, or an option requiring an application and approval before treating it as money ready to pay the school. Have the school identify the current steps. Do not accept debt simply to clear a task from the student's list.

For your comparison, use only borrowing you actually intend to pursue, and mark unconfirmed approval separately. Ask the school to distinguish the amount borrowed from the amount expected to reach the student account. Check StudentAid.gov for the current loan terms, limits and fees; no figure from an earlier award year belongs in this budget by default.

A suggested way to finance the gap isn't proof your family can afford it.

Work-study gets a note, not a discount

Federal Work-Study is the awkward line for a three-column sheet because it is neither a grant nor a loan. Put a note below the columns: "possible earnings; not upfront aid."

Federal Student Aid’s “8 Things You Should Know About Federal Work-Study,” checked October 5, 2026, explains that the student still needs a job. A school may help match students to positions, but an award is not itself a hiring decision. Your student may need to apply and interview.

The **2026-27** handbook’s work-study chapter says compensation is earned by performing the work. That is why the award amount shouldn’t be treated as a credit already sitting on the tuition account. Check StudentAid.gov and the school’s employment office for the current process and available jobs.

Keep potential earnings out of the grant total and today’s available cash. The student may earn less than the listed amount if the job starts later or fewer hours fit around classes. Ask how pay reaches the student and when it starts. Chapter 11 covers work arrangements.

If a bill is due before the student has worked, record the timing gap rather than covering it with a future paycheck that doesn’t exist yet and cannot pay today’s charge.

Build the third column from the full cost

The third column starts with cost of attendance, not tuition alone. Federal Student Aid’s dictionary describes cost of attendance as the school’s total attendance cost, including expenses beyond tuition. COA is the abbreviation you may see on an offer.

According to the **2026-27** handbook’s “Cost of Attendance (Budget)” chapter, that budget estimates educational expenses for the enrollment period. Its categories include tuition and fees, course materials, living expenses and transportation, subject to the rules it describes. Ask for the school’s applicable **2027-28** budget rather than carrying those older mechanics forward.

Separate charges billed by the school from expenses paid elsewhere: while tuition is a bill, a transportation allowance

estimates what you may spend getting around and off-campus rent may go to a landlord. A small school-account balance can coexist with substantial costs outside that account.

Federal Student Aid’s dictionary defines **net price** as attendance cost minus grants and scholarships. Calculate that first, before subtracting loans or potential work earnings. Label it “net price before financing” so the third column cannot quietly turn into a smaller, more comforting number.

Savings and family payments can fund that price. They aren’t a school discount. Keep them below the net-price line as your possible payment sources, without turning this into a savings-strategy exercise.

Call the amount left after identified funding the “remaining funding gap,” not net price. Keep proposed loans visible in the middle column even if their expected proceeds would reduce an immediate bill. Otherwise a family can report a tiny gap while hiding the debt used to make it tiny.

For bills coming due, ask the school which aid is expected to be credited, what remains pending and when payment is required. The current bill and full-year price calculations serve different purposes.

The three-column napkin, using your offer

Here’s the move. Take the actual offer and a blank sheet. A napkin is optional; mine wasn’t a filing system.

1. Write the school, award year, covered terms and offer date at the top. Confirm the cost period and enrollment assumptions.
2. In “grants and scholarships,” copy each confirmed gift-aid line and its amount. Add conditions beside it; leave unresolved lines outside the total.

3. In “loans,” copy each borrowing line separately. Identify the borrower and mark whether application, approval or acceptance remains unresolved.
4. In “what we pay,” enter the matching attendance cost, subtract the confirmed gift aid, and label the result net price before financing. Distinguish billed charges from estimated outside expenses.
5. Below the columns, note possible work-study earnings and other payment sources. Record a remaining gap only after identifying the funding you plan to use; don’t count any source twice.

Apply it line by line. If your offer lists a school scholarship, a student Direct Loan, Parent PLUS and work-study, the scholarship enters the first column. Both loans enter the second, under their respective borrowers. Work-study stays underneath as possible earnings. Your third-column starting result uses the attendance cost and scholarship amount, not the sum of every aid line.

Your offer supplies the amounts, not a fictional grant maximum or sample loan limit. An unclear line is a question to resolve before the total means anything.

For another school, start a fresh sheet using the same period and comparable living arrangements. Compare net prices first, then compare the borrowing and cash needed to meet them. The school with more aid printed at the top isn’t necessarily the one with less left to pay.

Keep renewal information beside each school’s current-year result. Don’t choose between a renewable award and a first-year-only award as if their conditions were interchangeable.

Keep proof, then ask a precise question

When Anika's offers were late, I saved the confirmations and called every school she was still considering. I wrote down what each office said needed attention and asked when we should expect the next update. Screenshots gave me something concrete to discuss instead of "we did everything, I think."

They didn't buy us more aid. They helped us establish what we knew.

Save each offer version with its date and conditions, alongside application confirmation numbers and document-receipt acknowledgments. Retain superseded offers; check which lines changed before updating your comparison.

If an offer is missing, use the financial aid office's contact details on the school's own website. Ask whether its record is complete, whether anything is outstanding, and when the office expects to issue an offer. Ask for the expected timeline in writing. Another family's arrival date is not a processing promise for yours.

If an amount is unclear, call that office because its staff can explain this student's package and its conditions. The help is free. Have your student participate and ask what permission the office needs to discuss their record with you. Send sensitive documents only through the method the school specifies.

A useful message is brief: "We're reviewing the offer for the stated award year. Please confirm whether this named line is gift aid or borrowing, whether the amount covers the whole year, and what remains before it can be paid."

Use the deadline map from Chapter 8 to identify any decision approaching while you wait. Ask about additional decision time if necessary; don't assume it has been granted. If the offer reflects finances that no longer fit your household, Chapter 10 covers the documented review request. Don't repair that problem by changing numbers on your comparison sheet.

Tonight, move the first unclear line out of your total and into a message to the aid office. Ten minutes to start. Leave the borrowing column where everyone at the table can see it.

Chapter 10: When the Number Doesn't Fit Your Life Anymore

The tax information on the form was accurate. The number still felt like it belonged to a different family.

Vikram had been laid off in 2024. On an earlier FAFSA, the tax-year information didn't show the change the way our kitchen table did: one paycheck gone, new pay stubs coming in, bills still arriving on schedule. We made a short folder for the school's financial aid office. A termination notice went in first. Then the records the office asked us to provide. The school reviewed the situation, and its special-circumstances process addressed the gap between the older tax picture and what had happened since.

There was no magic sentence. There was a specific office, a documented change, and a request that could be evaluated. That is the whole shape of this chapter.

The Form Looks Back, Your Life Doesn't

StudentAid.gov's live filing page for 2027-28 identifies 2025 as the tax year requested (checked October 5, 2026). A tax return describes a past year. It cannot, by itself, show every change after that year: a layoff, a substantial cut in hours, a separation, a medical crisis, or income that arrived once and did not repeat.

The form is not necessarily wrong when its tax information fails to describe today's household. It's answering from the information the form requests. If the circumstances have materially changed, the next step is not to try to make the old tax figures say something they

don't. First complete and submit the FAFSA with accurate answers. Then contact the financial aid office at the school the student plans to attend, explain the change, and ask for that school's special-circumstances review instructions.

A special-circumstances review is a school review, not a second FAFSA review run by the Department. In its 2026-27 Application and Verification Guide, Chapter 5, the Department permits an aid administrator to use professional judgment to adjust certain documented data elements used to determine Pell eligibility or calculate the Student Aid Index, then recalculate the SAI from those adjusted inputs. Professional judgment means the administrator evaluates the documented facts in an individual case. It does not mean the family chooses a different formula or controls the result.

The 2026-27 handbook is the current published reference named here, not a promise about the 2027-28 rules. Check StudentAid.gov and the handbook for the award year you're filing. The form itself is live for 2027-28; the annual handbook guidance for that year still needs to be published and checked. Keep those two facts separate.

Ask the office that can answer

Contact the financial aid office at each school where your student is seeking aid. A general message to "FAFSA" can disappear into the wrong queue. The school is the place to ask about that school's review, documentation, timing, and offer. It is also the office that can tell you whether it will consider the change and what it needs to see.

Start in writing. Keep the note brief and specific. Say what changed, when it changed, and that you want to ask about a special-circumstances review. Ask what documents are required, how to submit them securely, and whether the review needs to happen before the school prepares or revises an offer. Do not assume every

college uses the same form or deadline. Get the instructions from that school's office and save its reply.

Here's the move. Write one plain sentence before you call or open the school's portal: "Our household income changed when ____ on ____; what documentation do you need to review this?" Fill in the blanks with the real event and date. No argument. No estimate disguised as a fact.

This is not the same as asking a school to correct a typo on a submitted FAFSA, and it is not a request for the Department to replace your tax return. Tell the school if you also found an error in the form; ask which correction route applies. A special-circumstances review addresses a documented situation under the school's process. Don't quietly change a tax figure or asset answer to make the application resemble your current budget.

Bring evidence, not just the story

A personal explanation matters, but a narrative alone may not give the administrator enough to evaluate the change. Make the timeline easy to follow and attach the records the office requests. The right documents depend on what happened and the school's instructions.

For a job loss, that might begin with a termination letter or employer notice showing the effective date. Recent pay stubs can help show what income looks like now; if pay varies, ask the school which period or records it wants. If unemployment benefits or severance are involved, don't guess how they should be treated. List the facts and ask the aid office what documentation belongs in the review.

For a reduction in hours or pay, gather the employer's notice and current pay records. If a household member changed jobs, include the dates and records that distinguish the old income from the new one. For income received only once, such as a payment that will not

recur, identify what it was, when it arrived, and what record supports it. Ask the office whether that event is relevant to a review; an unusual payment is not automatically removed just because it happened once.

A medical crisis may have changed expenses or income. Keep the bills and records together, but do not assume every expense can be counted or that the school will adjust for it. Ask the office what it considers and which documents it needs. If the underlying tax return itself may be wrong, talk to the tax preparer or a CPA about the return. The aid office evaluates aid documentation; it does not replace tax advice.

Use a one-page cover note to connect the papers:

- What changed, and the date it changed.
- What the household's situation was before and after, in plain language.
- Which documents support each statement.
- What question you want the school to answer.

Keep a copy of everything sent, the date, and the submission confirmation. Use the secure portal or delivery method named by the school. A folder on your kitchen table is fine while assembling papers; sensitive tax and medical records should go where the school tells you to send them, not into an ordinary email thread unless the office specifically directs that method.

The first packet does not need a speech. It needs a readable timeline and evidence that matches it. If a document is missing, say so and ask what substitute the office accepts. Don't manufacture certainty where you don't have it.

What professional judgment can change

The Department's 2026-27 Handbook, in its chapter on special cases, describes professional judgment as authority for an aid administrator to adjust certain data elements used for Pell eligibility or the SAI when the circumstances are documented. The administrator may recalculate the SAI using the adjusted inputs. That can matter when the standard tax-year picture no longer fits the facts the family can document.

There are limits. Under the 2026-27 handbook, an administrator cannot rewrite the statutory formula. A school-specific review is not an amendment to the federal tax return, an assurance that a particular grant will follow, or an instruction for another college to make the same adjustment. The handbook says the adjusted SAI governs that student's Title IV aid at the school making the adjustment. Another school may evaluate its own review under its own process.

That means one school saying yes does not automatically settle the question at every school on the list. Send each school the request it asks for. Keep the record of which office reviewed what. If the family has several offers, don't copy one school's decision into another school's application as if the Department had changed the underlying record for everybody.

No success-rate number belongs here. Neither does a typical dollar amount. A review may affect the result, or the administrator may decide the documentation does not support an adjustment. The useful thing you control is the quality of the question and the evidence, not the answer the school will reach.

If the office declines to adjust the information, ask what part of the request it could not use and whether a missing record or a clearer date would help it understand the facts. Ask for the explanation in writing, especially if you are trying to distinguish a denied adjustment from a request that is still incomplete. Don't argue by

sending the same packet again with a stronger adjective. Respond to the actual question the office raised. If the household's circumstances change again, tell the office and ask whether it wants a new request or an update to the one already under review. Keep each school's answer in its own folder. A decision at one college is not a shortcut around another college's process.

If you're unsure whether a rule in this section remains current for 2027-28, check the published guidance on StudentAid.gov and ask the school's aid office. Don't treat the 2026-27 handbook's professional-judgment details as a promise that they carry forward unchanged.

This is not a dependency override

An income change and a dependency question are different problems. Special circumstances, as used here, means a change in a family's financial circumstances that the school may review. A dependency override concerns whether a student who would otherwise be dependent can be treated as independent because of qualifying unusual circumstances. It does not mean a parent lost a job, refuses to help, or simply will not complete the form.

Chapter 6 explains dependency status and the unusual-circumstances process. I won't re-run that checklist here. If the issue is safety, inability to contact a parent, or another circumstance affecting dependency, tell the aid office that directly and ask for its process. Don't package it as an income appeal just because both questions end up at the same office.

If you cannot tell which kind of review fits, say exactly what happened and ask the aid administrator to route the question. A school can explain its process; the 2026-27 handbook is the source for the dated federal framework. If a family-law order or disputed legal status is involved, a family-law attorney can advise on that legal

issue. The aid office is not your lawyer, and this chapter isn't one either.

Timing is part of the request

Don't wait for an offer to disappoint you before mentioning a change that is already real. Contact the school when you can describe what happened and begin collecting proof. Some reviews may need to be considered before an offer is prepared; the school will tell you its timing and whether it can review an existing offer. There is no universal turnaround time or fixed order of processing to promise.

If the change is still uncertain, don't submit a guessed annual income as if it were final. Ask the aid office how it handles an incomplete or changing picture, what date it uses, and whether it wants a later update. Write down the name of the office, the date you asked, and the next step it gave you. If the reply is unclear, ask one smaller question. A clean question gets a cleaner answer than a long email built around panic.

The same applies if the school says it cannot make an adjustment. Ask which document or fact was missing and whether there is another review route. The answer may still be no. You deserve to understand what the school considered and what to do next, without being promised an outcome no one can promise.

Build a packet you can actually send

Here's the move. Put one page on top, not a stack of unrelated records. The page should name the change, its date, the records attached, and the decision or instruction you are asking the school to provide. Then use the school's own list to confirm that the packet is complete.

Your working checklist:

- The financial change and the date it began.
- The school's written instructions for the review and secure submission method.
- Supporting records requested by the school, such as an employer notice or current pay information when relevant.
- A short cover note matching each statement to a document.
- A copy of the packet and proof of when it was submitted.
- A reminder to follow up if the school gives you a date or asks for more information.

Don't include account passwords, full Social Security numbers in an unsecured note, or extra medical records the office did not request. If you're not sure whether a document is necessary, ask before sending it. A school financial aid office can tell you what it needs for its review. A CPA or tax preparer can help if the problem is the tax return itself, rather than the difference between that return and a later event.

Vikram's folder did not erase what happened. It let the school see the dates and documents without asking us to turn a hard year into a perfect paragraph. That's a better standard for this request: clear enough to review, honest about what you know, and specific about what you need the school to decide.

Write the first sentence and find the office's instructions. Ten minutes. Tonight.

Chapter 11: Loans, Work-Study and Scholarships, Sorted

The pen is hovering over the loan amount. You know which part of the offer is debt now. You still don't know how much of it to accept.

Put the pen down for a minute.

The three-column sort from Chapter 9 identified the money. Now consider its obligations: interest, a work schedule, a parent's signature, or a scholarship that changes another award.

My order is confirmed grants and scholarships, then workable employment and the student's federal loans. Private borrowing comes last. Parent borrowing deserves a separate conversation.

Federal describes the lender, not an escape hatch

A Direct Loan comes from the U.S. Department of Education. A private education loan comes from a nonfederal lender, perhaps a bank or credit union. The Department defines both in its financial aid dictionary; I checked those entries on October 5, 2026. Identify the loan program before relying on a familiar company name.

Federal loan terms operate within federal law. Private terms depend on the loan contract, subject to applicable consumer law. Neither kind is a gift.

The Department's loan-comparison guidance describes Direct Loans as having a fixed interest rate. That rate doesn't move with market changes, although future loans may carry different rates.

Private loans can have fixed or variable rates. A variable rate can change under the contract, bringing a different payment with it.

Borrower protections matter alongside interest. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau’s “Choosing a loan that’s right for you,” checked October 5, 2026, describes federal options for reducing or postponing payments that private lenders need not duplicate. Eligibility matters. A federal label doesn’t establish that every repayment plan or relief option applies to every borrower.

Check StudentAid.gov for the options available to your loan type and borrowing date, including the Department’s current program-update notices. Don’t base a repayment plan on a neighbor’s older loan. This book prints no 2027-28 interest rate, fee or borrowing limit, and carries no earlier figure forward.

Request a total repayment estimate under the proposed terms. If it relies on forgiveness or income you cannot substantiate, request another without that assumption, so you can see the obligation without the hoped-for rescue.

Subsidized means help with interest

Federal Student Aid explains interest responsibility in [its comparison of subsidized and unsubsidized loans](#), checked October 5, 2026. Both require eligible enrollment of at least half time under that guidance.

Direct Subsidized Loans are for eligible undergraduates with financial need. The Department’s dictionary explains that the government covers interest while the borrower attends at least half time, during the qualifying grace period and during qualifying deferment. A grace period is the interval after leaving school or dropping below half-time attendance before scheduled repayment begins. Deferment is an approved postponement of payments under applicable conditions.

Principal is the amount borrowed. The government doesn't repay it. Your student owes that amount and bears interest outside the covered periods. Check StudentAid.gov for the loan's conditions; don't turn "while in school" into "regardless of enrollment."

Direct Unsubsidized Loans do not require demonstrated financial need under the Department's explanation, but other eligibility requirements still apply. The borrower is responsible for interest throughout the loan's periods, including eligible in-school attendance. Interest starts accumulating when funds are disbursed — paid out — rather than waiting until graduation.

No required monthly payment yet does not mean no cost yet.

If borrowing is necessary and both types are offered, the Department recommends using the subsidized option before unsubsidized borrowing. It also says you may request less than the loan amount offered. Ask the school how to request that smaller amount.

Before funds can be received, the Department's dictionary identifies a Master Promissory Note, the borrower's legal repayment promise, and entrance counseling for first-time student borrowers. Counseling explains responsibilities; it isn't another name for signing the promise. Check StudentAid.gov and the school for your required steps. Your FAFSA signature did not sign a loan agreement.

Parent PLUS needs a parent's budget

Parent PLUS is separate borrowing by an eligible parent for a dependent undergraduate's education. As established in Chapter 9, its repayment responsibility belongs to that parent. The practical question is whether the parent can carry that obligation alongside the bills already arriving at home.

"My child will pay me back" may describe your family arrangement. It does not make the child the federal borrower. Don't

sign on the assumption that the obligation automatically changes names after graduation.

Using current terms, put the proposed payment into the parent's budget and ask when payments start. Consider what happens if the student cannot contribute. Discuss that before signing.

Parent PLUS borrowing is capped under rules effective in 2026. Before budgeting a proposed amount, ask the school's aid office to check how much remains available for this student after earlier borrowing and whether a transition exception applies. Do not assume Parent PLUS can fill the entire gap; verify the applicable limit at [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov).

That is a change in how this loan used to work, and it is worth being precise about. The old shorthand was that a parent could borrow up to the school's cost of attendance minus the student's other financial aid. [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov)'s PLUS page, checked October 5, 2026, now says the maximum PLUS amount a borrower can receive depends on the new loan limits established in the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, with a limited interim exception the online application cannot evaluate and the school ultimately determines. The Department's loan-program final rule, published May 1, 2026, carries the detail. So the cost-of-attendance-minus-aid figure is a ceiling the school still applies, not the whole answer. Ask for both numbers in writing: what the gap is, and what this parent is actually permitted to borrow for this student this year.

[StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov)'s dictionary distinguishes parent PLUS from student Direct Subsidized and Unsubsidized Loans: parent PLUS has no grace period, although qualifying deferment may be requested. Check [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov) for the current eligibility and deferment terms. Postponement of payments should never be mistaken for a promise that interest stops.

I would not put Parent PLUS and student Direct Loans in one acceptance pile. The CFPB's loan-selection page cautions that its

preference for student federal loans is not automatically the same comparison for a parent considering PLUS.

Read private borrowing from the hard end

Consider private borrowing after investigating gift aid, feasible earnings and federal options. Knowing those alternatives doesn't mean taking an unaffordable parent loan.

Compare actual offers, including fees and repayment schedules; don't substitute advertised rates for the terms you qualify for, or compare a fixed rate with a variable one without reading how it changes. Find out whether payments begin during enrollment and what happens to interest during any postponement.

Then read the cosigner section.

A cosigner shares legal responsibility for repayment; they aren't supplying a character reference. The CFPB's [cosigner explanation](#), checked October 5, 2026, warns that missed payments can harm both people's credit. A parent who cosigns should be prepared to repay if the student cannot.

Cosigner release removes that person's obligation under the lender's conditions. The CFPB's release guidance says some private loans offer it, with criteria in the terms or on the lender's website. Available isn't approved.

Ask whether this exact loan permits release, how to apply, and which conditions govern the decision. If on-time payments or a new assessment of the student's finances are required, get those details in writing. Don't invent a release date from an advertisement or treat graduation as release. If the contract offers no release, weigh it as an obligation that may remain for the loan's life.

The other section worth reading slowly is missed payments. Locate any late fee, the lender's reporting policy and the conditions for default — failure to repay under the agreement. Ask what

hardship arrangements exist, who approves them and whether interest continues. No answer is not a hardship policy.

The CFPB's payment-difficulty guidance says private lenders have different options rather than a standard federal-style menu. Contact the servicer, the company handling payments, promptly if trouble develops. Don't stop paying because a request is being considered; get confirmation of any approved change.

Before signing, call the school's financial aid office if you cannot reconcile the requested private amount with the remaining aid or cost period. Its staff can explain packaging and any school certification process, not make the loan affordable for you. If a disputed contract term needs legal interpretation, consult an attorney and ask about fees. A lender's sales explanation isn't independent legal advice.

Work-study has to fit between classes

Work-study stays outside the upfront-aid total, as Chapter 9 explained. Here the task is deciding whether an actual position fits the student's week.

Federal Student Aid's work-study article, checked October 5, 2026, directs awarded students to the school's employment resources: a school may match students with positions, or require applications and interviews. Have your student find the current vacancies and application instructions. Accepting an award and accepting a job are different actions.

Federal Work-Study, sometimes shortened to FWS, supports part-time employment for eligible students with financial need. The **2026-27 handbook's campus-based-program chapter on FWS** describes government funding toward wages, with school or other nonfederal contributions and exceptions. That funding

arrangement is the school's responsibility. Your student still works the job and follows its employment requirements.

Read the duties, location and hours before deciding. Ask the supervisor about shifts around labs, exams and travel between buildings. "On campus" isn't enough information if the shift starts before a class across campus ends.

Under the **2026-27 work-study guidance**, schools consider academic workload and factors affecting available work hours. Undergraduate wages are hourly, and earnings depend on the work performed. The school specifies how much the student is authorized to earn. Ask how to track that amount and what happens as the student approaches it; continuing employment from another funding source is not automatic.

The same **2026-27 chapter** requires payment at least monthly and advance notice of the payment arrangements. For **2027-28**, check StudentAid.gov, then get the school's payroll instructions, first pay date and time-record procedure before budgeting from a vacancy's headline wage.

Compare take-home pay with commuting costs and the time needed to study. My preference is a job the student can actually keep over a theoretical schedule that fills every spare hour. A missed lab is not an economical way to earn grocery money.

Ask about ordinary campus employment too if no suitable work-study position is available. A job need not carry the FWS label to be worth considering. Don't assume an ordinary job receives identical aid treatment; check StudentAid.gov and ask the aid office about the current rules before making that comparison.

Scholarships need a smaller, better search

Federal Student Aid's [scholarship-finding page](#), checked October 5, 2026, separates merit awards from awards based on financial need.

Merit can mean academic achievement, a particular talent or another standard the provider sets. It doesn't always mean top grades. Need-based awards use financial criteria. Some awards combine conditions or serve a particular group.

Read eligibility before writing an essay.

Start with the college's scholarship office, the high-school counselor and employers connected to the family. The Department also names community organizations and the U.S. Department of Labor's free CareerOneStop scholarship search. These are places to look, not promises of an award. Follow a listing to the provider's own current application.

Record eligible opportunities with their source, deadline, required materials and submission status. Pending applications aren't budget money.

For each promising application, check its school or program restrictions and who must supply a recommendation. Ask the recommender before entering their name. Reuse your own background notes where appropriate, but answer the actual essay prompt rather than mailing the same paragraph everywhere.

The provider controls its requirements and deadline; there is no national date to copy here. Choose one eligible application whose materials you can assemble. That is more useful tonight than collecting a page of awards your student cannot receive.

Report the scholarship before spending it twice

When an outside award arrives, tell the school's aid office even if the provider sends the money directly to your student. StudentAid.gov's scholarship page says the office needs that information to account for other assistance. Ask the provider how payment will work, then send the school the award notice through its designated process.

An outside scholarship doesn't automatically stack on top of every existing award. Under the **2026-27 handbook's overaward guidance**, additional assistance can require changes when the package exceeds financial need or attendance cost. That is a packaging review, not permission to lower the school's stated price yourself.

Ask which lines change and request the revised offer before increasing spending or finalizing borrowing. The effect might include less loan eligibility; institutional adjustments depend on the school's award policies. No universal dollar-for-dollar outcome belongs here.

For the Pell restriction from Chapter 7: in **2026-27**, outside awards that reach the cost of attendance ordinarily bar Pell under Volume 7, **except for students qualifying under the Special Rule for certain deceased servicemembers' or public safety officers' children**. Ask the aid office to check whether it applies and which aid changes; do not assume the same rule for **2027-28**.

Report the award either way. Guessing its effect is no substitute for the school evaluating it.

The borrowing order, with a stop condition

Here's the move. Use this decision checklist beside the amount still unfunded, not as another award-letter sorting sheet.

1. Confirm available grants and scholarships and report outside awards. Use the package after any required adjustment.
2. Pursue a workable job. Use earnings only for expenses their timing can cover.
3. If borrowing remains necessary, consider the student's offered Direct Subsidized Loan before Direct Unsubsidized borrowing. Request only the needed amount.

4. Compare parent borrowing separately. Ask the aid office how much Parent PLUS remains available under the rules effective in 2026, and verify the applicable limit at [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov), before reading its current obligations against the parent's budget rather than the student's hopes.
5. Consider private borrowing last. Require clear repayment, hardship and cosigner terms, and keep the amount as small as the actual gap permits.

This is an order for evaluating options, not an instruction to use every one. If the gap still requires debt nobody can reasonably carry, stop. Reconsider the attendance plan before adding signatures.

Tonight, open the terms for the next loan you are considering. Find who owes it and when interest starts. Ten minutes to locate those answers. Leave the pen down until you can explain them.

Chapter 12: The Form Is Free. Say It Twice

The mailer looked official enough to leave on the kitchen counter. A neat seal, a photograph of a student in a cap, and one large promise: “We file your FAFSA for you.” The price was \$89.

I turned it over. No one at the Department of Education had sent it. The form itself costs nothing to submit. For 2026-27, the Federal Student Aid Handbook prohibited paid preparers; check the current 2027-28 form instructions at [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov). In every year, the FAFSA itself is free, and [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov) warns families not to pay a site to submit it.

That distinction matters. A company may sell general advice about paying for college. A person may help you understand a confusing question. But a fee to prepare or submit the FAFSA is not the same service, and a promise that a payment will secure aid deserves an immediate pause.

The FAFSA is free. Say it twice if the letter is persuasive.

Start at the actual front door

For 2027-28, the form is available through [StudentAid.gov](https://studentaid.gov). That is the official place to begin, and the Department’s live filling-out page identifies this cycle’s form and its requested tax year. I checked that guidance on October 5, 2026. Use the address you type yourself or a bookmark you made from the official site; don’t let a search advertisement or a mailer choose the destination for you.

Federal Student Aid’s page “Avoiding Student Aid Scams,” also checked October 5, 2026, says the FAFSA is free and directs families to StudentAid.gov. It warns that sites charging to help fill it out are not affiliated with or endorsed by the Department. The page points to free assistance from a college financial aid office, FAFSA online help and the Federal Student Aid Information Center.

The address is a useful first check. The official FAFSA service is on StudentAid.gov. A site with a similar name, an extra word, a different ending or a sponsored search label is not made official by a blue banner or a familiar eagle. Don’t enter personal information just because a page has copied the colors.

If you land somewhere unfamiliar, close it. Open a new browser window, type `StudentAid.gov` yourself, and navigate to the FAFSA from there. You do not need to pay a site to unlock the federal form, send it to a school, or get an application number. If a page asks for a credit card to submit the FAFSA, leave it.

This chapter is not saying every paid service involving college is a fraud. The Federal Student Aid scam page makes that distinction too: charging for advice alone does not prove that a company is fraudulent. What you should not confuse is a paid adviser discussing options with a paid preparer completing the federal form. The FAFSA itself remains free, and the actual filing rules need to be checked on the form for the award year you are using.

What the preparer label does — and doesn’t — mean

I checked Chapter 2 of the Federal Student Aid Handbook for **2026-27**: paid preparers are prohibited. In that edition, a Preparer section appears on the paper or PDF form for an **unpaid** person who completed part of the FAFSA on the applicant’s behalf. That label is

not permission for a company to charge for filing. It identifies the unpaid helper in that year's paper process.

That is a handbook rule for **2026-27**, not a claim about what a 2027-28 screen looks like. Check StudentAid.gov for the current form's instructions and roles. I have not inspected or authenticated a private account screen, so I won't invent its exact labels or buttons.

An unpaid person can sit beside you, help read a question aloud, or point you to the official explanation. You remain the one who knows whether the answer is true. Each required contributor uses their own StudentAid.gov account to complete and sign their part; don't hand over a password just because someone offers to type faster. Chapters 1 and 2 cover those steps. Here the point is simpler: assistance with understanding is not ownership of your account.

When an adviser offers a paid package, ask what the fee buys. If it is an optional planning conversation, compare the price and service carefully and remember free help is available. If the person says the fee is for submitting the FAFSA, getting it processed, releasing funds, or securing an award, don't pay on that claim. Ask the school's aid office to identify the official step instead.

Never let a preparer put words in your mouth. A false answer remains your family's problem after the preparer has cashed a check and disappeared. If you don't know how to answer something, pause and use StudentAid.gov's help page. Federal Student Aid's Information Center can also guide you through an unresolved question. A short pause costs less than signing a guess.

The offer that wants money, urgency, or your password

The mailer on the counter had one obvious hook: pay \$89 and somebody else would take care of the form. Other messages use different hooks. They may promise a grant that is "already

approved,” claim a payment will ensure more aid, or say the family will lose its chance unless a fee is paid right now.

Federal Student Aid’s scam guidance specifically warns about claims of assured aid and pressure to buy immediately. Such a promise is especially slippery: a company might call any offer — including borrowing — proof that it delivered. Chapter 9 showed why the word “aid” on a letter doesn’t tell you whether money is a grant, a loan or wages the student must earn. Don’t let a stranger use that ambiguity to sell certainty.

Another version arrives by phone, text or email. A caller may claim to represent the Department and ask for payment to release the FAFSA, fix a hold or send the application to colleges. The federal form costs nothing to file. Don’t give payment details or personal information to an unexpected caller. Hang up, then contact the school or Federal Student Aid through the contact route you reach from StudentAid.gov, not a number supplied in the message.

Then there’s the request for your FSA ID password. The FSA ID is your StudentAid.gov account sign-in. Federal Student Aid says not to tell anyone the username or password, even someone helping with the FAFSA. The password can be used to access the account and make changes. A real helper can explain a question without taking control of your identity.

Some requests are less theatrical. A website may look nearly right, use a government-sounding name or display a seal. A letter may include your name and a real school. Those details do not verify who sent it. Names and logos are easy to copy; the official domain and a contact method reached independently are better checks.

A three-question pause

Before replying, paying or signing, ask:

- Is someone charging specifically to prepare or submit the FAFSA, or promising that a fee will secure aid?
- Is anyone asking for a StudentAid.gov username or password, payment details, or a one-time verification code?
- Is the message pushing you to act immediately while asking you to use its link or callback number?

A yes is a stop sign, not a reason to negotiate. It doesn't prove every company that sells general financial-aid advice is fraudulent; it means you should verify what the service is, what the fee covers, and whether the federal filing remains yours. For FAFSA submission, return to StudentAid.gov. For an account or aid question, use the contact links at that site to find the school or Federal Student Aid staff.

Keep the message, envelope, receipt or screenshot if you think you were misled. Don't forward it to a stranger who claims to investigate. Use the reporting directions on StudentAid.gov's "Avoiding Student Aid Scams" page. If money has already left your account, contact your bank or card issuer using the number on its official card or website and ask what options apply. A payment dispute does not mean the money will be returned; describe exactly what was promised and delivered.

If someone already has your password

No scolding. Fix access first.

Go directly to StudentAid.gov by typing the address. Follow the current account-security instructions to change the password and review the account's contact details. Federal Student Aid's scam guidance tells people whose FSA ID information has been shared to change the password. If you cannot get into the account or see contact information you did not add, contact the Federal Student Aid

Information Center through StudentAid.gov's Help Center. Don't use a link from the person who had the password.

Tell your student and any other contributor who may be affected. Each person protects their own account; one password change does not secure a different contributor's login. If an application was changed or submitted without your agreement, contact the school's financial aid office and ask what it can see, what records it needs, and how to correct the situation. Use the school's secure method for documents. Do not send passwords or full account credentials in an email.

If you shared a password with a paid preparer, change it even if the person seems trustworthy. If they only helped read a question and never had the password, there may be nothing to repair. Keep the distinction plain; panic makes every kind offer look like a threat and every threat look like a kind offer.

If you paid a company but did not share a password, keep the contract, advertisement, messages and proof of payment. Contact the company only through contact details you verify independently if you need to request a refund or records. If it claimed to be the Department, charged to submit the FAFSA, or did not provide the promised service, use StudentAid.gov's reporting guidance and consider contacting the Federal Trade Commission. A fee for advice is not automatically fraud; describe the facts rather than applying a label you can't support.

The help that is real

You can get help without surrendering the form. StudentAid.gov provides online FAFSA help. A college's financial aid office can answer questions about its process and its own aid. The Federal Student Aid Information Center handles federal application and

account questions. Those routes are free; start from StudentAid.gov or the school's official website so you know whom you reached.

A tax preparer may help with the family's tax return. That is a different job from charging to prepare or submit the FAFSA. If you are unsure which tax-year information belongs on the form, or the return itself may need correction, take the tax question to your preparer or a certified public accountant. The aid office can help with the form, not amend a tax return. For the FAFSA field, use StudentAid.gov's explanation or ask the aid office. Don't ask one professional to make a claim outside their role.

And help does not mean someone else should make a contributor's account, supply the contributor's consent, or sign as that person. Chapter 2 separated those actions. Keep the password private, answer from the records you have, and ask about a question you cannot resolve. A competent helper will leave you in control.

A small check before you close the envelope

Here's the move. If a message or mailer offers to handle FAFSA, set it beside your computer and check three things before doing anything:

1. Go to StudentAid.gov by typing the address yourself. Confirm you're using the official federal form, not a look-alike service.
2. Read what the person is actually charging for. Advice is not the same as preparing or submitting the FAFSA; a promise of assured aid is not evidence.
3. Keep your account credentials to yourself. If they were shared, change the password using the official account route and contact the Information Center if access is uncertain.

Write the provider's name, the exact promise, the fee and the date on the back of the mailer. If any piece is vague, don't sign or pay yet.

Call the financial aid office or the Information Center from a contact page you opened yourself. You do not need to decide while the caller is waiting on the line.

The process can be long and still be legitimate. A slow page is not evidence that an \$89 service can fix it. Each contributor who completes their own section, provides required permission and signs through the proper route has done the work the application asks of them. If something looks wrong, stop and verify it at the official source.

Put the mailer in the recycling, or keep it if you need its details to report. Then open a fresh browser window and start at StudentAid.gov. Ten minutes. Tonight.

A Form, Not a Test

Rohan had his elbow on the yellow pad beside the fruit bowl. The laptop was open. He was reading, not typing, and his free hand kept finding the edge of the lid.

“I still don’t like this,” he said.

I had promised to sit beside him while we worked out what it was asking. There were still questions on our pad, and college still cost more than either of us wanted it to. But he could tell me which part had stopped him. The first evening, one unfamiliar word had sent him out the door.

He wasn’t suddenly calm. He was further along.

You may recognize that table. No delighted family holding a perfect award letter. No assurance that enough money will arrive because you were careful. A parent and a student who can stay with the page long enough to understand the question. Some evenings, that is quite a bit.

The questions arrived one at a time. So did the answers. What had looked like one enormous decision became the next question on the page.

You don’t have to recite that route. Nothing about recognizing an acronym on sight makes you a better parent. I’d rather you understood the sentence in front of you than remembered every abbreviation in these pages. We don’t need to make a family spelling bee out of them.

The important difference at our table was that a question could now be small. It could be about one account, one line in an offer, one fact we needed to confirm. Before, every unknown had seemed to

contain the whole college decision. Where would he go? Could we pay? Had we already ruined something? All of that crowded into the space beside a single field.

The worries didn't disappear when the field made sense. They did stop pretending to be the same worry.

You may still have a form in progress. You may have an offer you understand and a price you cannot comfortably meet. Reading to this page doesn't tell me which. I won't write your family's result into the blank space. Understanding a cost is not the same as having the money, and a clear explanation doesn't make an uncomfortable answer pleasant.

I don't like advice that treats a parent's worry as a failure of attitude. If the amount left to pay is beyond you, confidence isn't a payment source. If a family circumstance is complicated, a cheerful sentence doesn't settle it. You can be careful and still face a hard choice. That doesn't mean the careful work was wasted. It means you can see the choice without a misleading label covering it.

Recognizing the debt didn't decide whether the family could manage it. That was why the borrowing discussion needed its own space after the offer. I would distrust a book that chose for you without knowing the bills on your kitchen counter.

Where the handbook edition was older than this application cycle, I named it rather than quietly changing the year. The official sources throughout the book remain the places for current instructions. No missing figure appears here to make the story feel complete. An unanswered question is more useful than an answer borrowed from the wrong year.

Saving for college and choosing a 529 investment strategy remain outside this book; the IRS's "Qualified tuition programs" page and your state's plan information are starting places for that separate subject.

And the professional-help promise from the opening still stands. When your school's offer needs explanation or your circumstances need its review, the school's aid office is the place to call. Federal Student Aid names that office as a source of free help in "Avoiding Student Aid Scams"; its "Filling Out the FAFSA Form" guidance places changed-finances decisions with the school. I checked both on October 5, 2026. For a change to that school's offer, the authority is there, not with me. You aren't supposed to become an aid administrator to ask for help from one.

I know the urge to apologize before asking. You have read something twice and still cannot tell what it means. You imagine the person answering has heard the question all day. At the front counter, I much preferred a parent who could say where they were stuck to one who nodded and left with an answer they hadn't understood. I could explain a form. I could not know what silence meant.

That old habit followed me home. I had to remember it when the parent at the table was me. Being able to explain a word didn't give me authority over the outcome, and being worried didn't make me unfit to ask a question.

Rohan moved his elbow. The pad had a crease through the line we'd been discussing. He smoothed it with his palm and looked back at the screen. I left the laptop within his reach, rather than pulling it toward me to hurry things along.

He read the sentence again. Then he pointed to the words he didn't understand.

This time, he stayed.